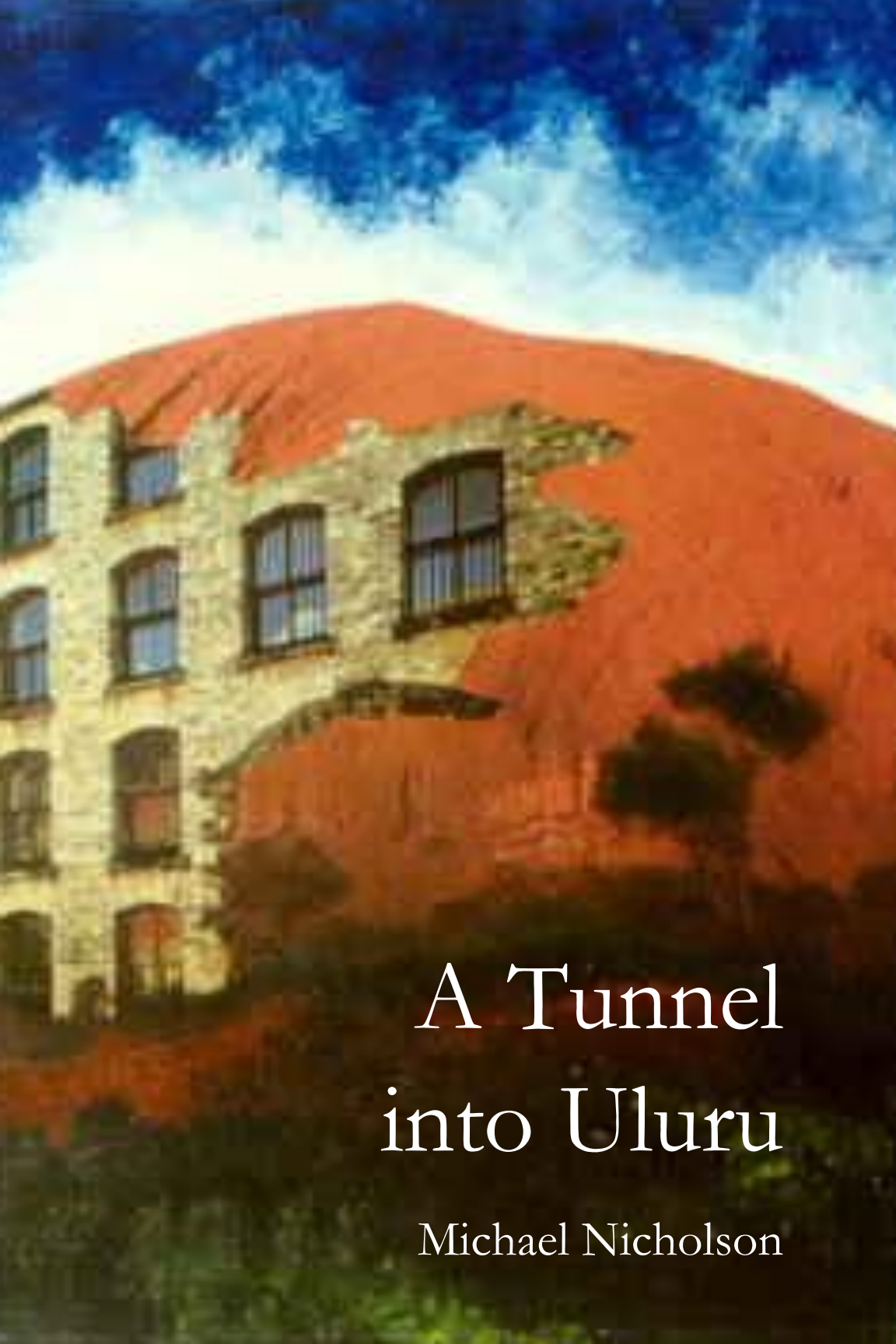




A Tunnel into Uluru

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By

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Chapter One

Hiking Around Uluru

‘... It’s like a dream... we’re dreaming... it’s dream time...’

“It’s not a dream. It’s a monolith... a huge rock”, Yvonne said with a slightly dreamy frown that turned into a beautiful smile as she gazed at Sebastian.

The five students climbed out of the mini bus holding their backpacks and bags at 5.30 in the morning. The sun appeared over the Central Australian horizon and the bus drove away leaving them standing on the roadside of the Uluru-Kata Tjuta National Park and all there was was the rock. You couldn’t miss it since Uluru is one of the most famous landmarks on earth.

“Are you really our guide? I must be dreaming”, Sebastian mumbled as he looked directly into the eyes of Yvonne.

“You are not dreaming. I am your guide. I am nearly a full-blooded Australian aborigine. My grandfather married a white nurse, so I have a bit of Anglo Saxon blood in my veins but I am still your aboriginal guide, nonetheless...”

They were all in their early twenties and from Melbourne, except for Yvonne who was from Alice Springs. They were four university students on a trip to Central Australia and on this day they were setting out to hike around the base of Uluru.

“Look! A dingo!” Cathy exclaimed in scared excitement as a large dingo emerged from the scrub and then stopped in the middle of the road. Cathy scrambled to unzip her backpack and fumbled for her camera.

A larger tourist bus speeded towards the dingo that turned to run away but suddenly, for no explicable reason, turned again and froze. The bus skidded, the horn blared, Cathy clicked her camera and in the confusion the bus hit the dingo.

Through the camera lens she saw the dingo thrown to the gravel roadside. Japanese tourists inside the bus peered out the window in horror.

The dust settled and momentarily there was silence. A dingo pup emerged from the scrub searching for its mother and in dreaded anticipation the sorrowful yelping interrupted the silence. It was a miserable situation.

The drivers door of the red tourist bus was flung open and a large man jumped out cursing his luck. He knelt over the body of the dingo and felt for a heartbeat and glanced at the small amount of blood splattered on his bull bar. Finally he grabbed the dingos rear paws and dragged it back into the scrub.

Cathy looked at the red tourist bus framed by Uluru. Through her lens it looked like the huge red rock had windows with Japanese tourists crowded against them staring out.

The large man returned to the bus and as he clambered back into the drivers seat he stopped and looked at the group of astounded students.

“Well?” he growled in a matter-of-fact way, “I tried to swerve; it’s the dogs fault. I’m sorry...”

He slammed the door and the rear tyres skidded in the gravel leaving another cloud of dust as the bus drove away at high speed.

“Leave it!” Yvonne called to Sebastian as he ran defiantly into the scrub and within seconds returned holding a whimpering dingo puppy. Cathy immediately

“Oh, you poor little thing”, Cathy moaned in sympathy as she went to Sebastian’s side and started cuddling the sad animal, “You come with us.”

“And we’ll call you Anzaria!” Jonathon said, trying to alleviate the sad situation. This created a further awkward pause then everyone broke into spontaneous laughter.

“Don’t be stupid”, Cathy replied reprimanding the others, “we’ll call her ‘Zara’”

After strolling along the path for an hour directly below the huge imposing Uluru only the dingo pup scampering between their feet reminded them of the unfortunate accident.

They had met their guide, Yvonne, for the first time that morning because they had refused to join the much larger tour group that was planning to climb Uluru. So, their tour organiser, Albert Harrison, had hastily arranged an Aboriginal guide to walk with them around the base of the rock.

“Actually you don’t really need me”, Yvonne concluded as they passed another sign explaining where they were and how many kilometres they had covered, “everything is clearly marked and these notices tell you more than I know anyway.”

“Forgive me, but you give us a feeling for the place Yvonne”, Sebastian clarified quickly, since he could hardly stop looking at her.

Maybe it was her beautiful smile, or her slightly curly hair, or even the rhythm of her walking style that Sebastian felt drawn to.

The other two male students were no less impressed. Jonathan, the stockier of the two, wore rimless glasses and had a ruthless, but pragmatic sense of humour.

Kim, with a tough wire-like frame, was incredibly intelligent and light-years ahead of everyone, including his tutors, in all areas of electronics and computer technology.

Sebastian, a natural leader, was tall and handsome whom no mortal would dare duel. He was responsible for galvanising the group to refuse to climb Uluru on the grounds it was offensive to local aborigines.

“I’m not offended if you climb my rock”, Yvonne had explained patiently, “it’s a rock, and it’s been here for millions of years and is no different to any other rock.”

“Yes, but its common knowledge that some elders don’t like people violating their sacred sites”, Sebastian politely argued.

“No Sebastian”, Yvonne refuted, “they’re scared tourists will fall off it. Do you understand?”

“Anyway, I don’t think we should sit too close to the rock in case one of the other students falls on us”, Jonathon said as they decided to rest and have breakfast. A hot sun had replaced any morning chill and the shade of the various gum trees only mildly alleviated the heat.

“I don’t remember packing these”, Jonathon mumbled as he unzipped his heavy backpack and started urgently searching the large pockets. He found a bag of canned foods, “they’re not mine, and this mobile phone; I don’t even own one... and this wallet belongs to Mr. Harrison!”

The others looked over in puzzled interest as Jonathan uncovered a pouch of compasses and assorted navigational equipment and finally a bulky wallet.

‘This must be Albert Harrison’s backpack and he must have mine’, Jonathan thought to himself, ‘and Albert has probably discovered this on top of Uluru.’

“Zara! Come back here”, Cathy called out as the dingo puppy scurried through some shrubs towards the rock, “I’ll give you a sandwich”. Cathy followed the puppy right up to the face of the rock.

Her heart skipped a beat and her throat suddenly contracted as she blinked in disbelief at what she saw. The head of the dingo puppy had seemingly gone into the rock. Then it came out again as it continued sniffing around.

Cathy couldn’t believe what she had just seen and then it happened again. This time the entire puppy, except its wagging tail, passed into the actual rock.

Cathy instinctively lunged forward and grabbed the tail and with the momentum her hand also momentarily went into the rock before she pulled the puppy out. Zara was fine and the rock appeared as solid as before.

A cold shiver raced up Cathy’s back and she sat down to compose herself as her heart began to beat fast and she carefully crawled backwards still clutching the puppy. Cathy then grabbed a stick and threw it at the rock and the stick disappeared into the rock.

“Where’s Cathy?” Yvonne enquired looking around. The boys were immersed in Albert Harrison’s backpack and didn’t pay any attention, so Yvonne stood up and strolled into the scrub and soon found Cathy standing rigid in shock. “Cathy...?” Yvonne said with a bewildered smile.

“What’s happened?” Sebastian enquired as the other three turned up, “Are you alright Cathy?” She stood there stroking the dingo pup.

“Watch this”, Cathy stated as she grabbed a stick and threw it at the rock. The stick disappeared into the rock and didn’t bounce off. Suddenly the puppy struggled free and rushed off to fetch the stick and before their very eyes the puppy disappeared into the rock completely. Gone. Vanished.

‘Are we dreaming? Is this a dream...?’

“This can’t be...” Jonathan said as he adjusted his rimless glasses, “it’s solid rock.”

“I think we should get out of here”, Yvonne urged, “let’s get back to the track and go home... I don’t understand what I’ve just seen. I’m sorry.”

“Not so fast”, Kim replied calmly as he strolled over to the exact place in the rock where the dingo puppy had disappeared, “there must be a reason for this.”

Before anyone could do anything, Kim put his hand into the rock, then his arm, then his head and shoulders and then as quickly pulled them out and looked at the rest of the group.

They all stood aghast with their eyes wide open in surprise.

“It’s a cave of some sort in there, quite well lit”, Kim stated in a matter-of-fact way.

“... But you went through solid rock!” Sebastian spluttered out with a quiver in his voice.

“Well, it felt like thin air. Not solid rock at all, I promise”, Kim argued and then he walked right into the rock and

disappeared completely. Kim was gone. The rest of the group stood motionless. Yvonne started to cry.

“I’m your guide and I’ll be in so much trouble”, she sobbed as Cathy put her arm around her.

“No, no, it’s not your fault at all”, Cathy said as she began to cry also.

No one knew what to do, least of all Sebastian who was supposed to be a leader. His immediate thought was to get help but what would he say, ‘We need the police here, someone has walked through solid rock?’

‘Bip, bip... bip, bip... bip, bip’ the eerie silence was broken by the distinct sounds of a text message from a mobile phone.

“But we don’t have a mobile phone”, Jonathan said.

“Yes, we do, Albert Harrison’s”, Sebastian replied in relief as they ran the short distance to their backpacks.

Sebastian fumbled through their tour leaders’ belongings and finally located the mobile phone. He switched on the text message and read it out aloud.

‘ENJOY THE VIEW!’

“Who’s it from?” Jonathan enquired as they looked at each other mysteriously.

“It’s from Harrison’s wife”, Sebastian replied as he pressed a few buttons and revealed the sender.

They all quickly solved the puzzle. Mrs. Harrison was back at the main camp and had obviously sent a text message to her husband knowing he was by now on top of Uluru with the rest of the class and probably enjoying the panoramic views.

“Well? Come on Sebastian!” Cathy ordered angrily as they walked back to the rock face, “Call for help.”

“Yes, yes”, Sebastian replied as he fumbled to make a call.

Just as he began to find an emergency number on the mobile phone, they heard a dingo pup yelp and the familiar whistling nonchalance of Kim.

Cathy pointed her camera at the rock and through the viewfinder she saw Kim emerge from the solid rock smiling and holding the puppy and she took an amazing photograph of Kim seemingly half embedded in rock.

“You’re safe”, Cathy concluded in relief as they crowded around Kim.

The dingo pup played around happily oblivious to the science fiction dilemma that had unfolded. Sebastian tapped away on the mobile phone and put it to his ear as he looked blankly at the others.

“Hullo? Mrs. Harrison?” he said politely, “It’s Sebastian here... no, nothing’s wrong, I’ve got your husbands mobile phone by mistake. The backpacks got switched and a few of us didn’t climb Uluru after all... Bye.” He turned off the mobile phone and looked at the others with a judgmental frown.

“Well? She would have thought we were all mad if I told her Kim had walked through solid rock!” Sebastian claimed. Kim, meanwhile, had used a long stick to poke around the apparent hole in the rock.

After a while he discovered the height and width of the mysterious opening and it was the size of a garage door. He placed a couple of tall sticks on each side so they knew where the entrance was since they certainly couldn’t tell by looking at it. Visually it all looked like solid rock.

“There must be some logical explanation to all of this”, Kim said to the others, “Since clearly we’ve all witnessed it.”

“But you’re the only one who’s been through it Kim”, Jonathan argued, “So only you have experienced it.”

“Well then, I’ll give it a try”, Sebastian offered as he stood up and walked over to the area between the sticks.

“No don’t Sebastian!” Yvonne protested, “as your guide, I demand of you...” her voice trailed off in resignation as Sebastian walked through the rock and vanished.

Everyone stared in silence at the rock. Moments later Sebastian stepped out nodding his head.

“You’re right Kim, it’s just a cave in there...” he announced as they all thought for a moment.

“Maybe it’s an optical illusion of some sort”, Jonathan suggested as he adjusted his rimless glasses. “After all, there are lots of caves in this rock, are there not Yvonne?” he inquired looking at their guide.

“Well, yes... of course”, Yvonne replied uneasily, “Everyone knows that...”

Jonathon then bravely strode through the rock and returned before anyone could even blink or protest.

“Yep. It’s a cave”, Jonathan concurred.

“Alright then”, Sebastian announced, “let’s all go in and explore... how can that offend the aboriginal elders?”

“Oh. I get it”, Cathy replied curtly, “we shouldn’t climb over Uluru, but we can climb into it. How convenient.”

“So then, who’s coming?” Sebastian enquired confidently as he picked up his backpack followed by Kim and

Jonathan and the three of them strolled into the rock and were gone.

“Oh dear, and I’m the guide, I guess...” Yvonne said as she looked at Cathy. And with those words, Evonne and Cathy picked up their backpacks, held their collective breath, and marched through the rock after the three boys.

Chapter Two

Hiking Inside Uluru

“Well, here we all are then!” Sebastian announced inside the cave as Cathy and Yvonne emerged from the rock wall, “and at least it’s nice and cool”, he continued flapping his wet shirt from his sweaty chest. Kim, meanwhile, grabbed a few sticks they had thrown inside and placed them against the cave wall to show the exit.

“Where’s Zara?” Cathy asked, “We can’t leave her by herself”. At that moment Zara suddenly scampered out of the rock waving her tail and Cathy picked her up. “Who’s a lovely little puppy?” she said cuddling the dingo pup.

“Now listen Sebastian”, Yvonne said raising her voice causing a small echo, “we’re in this cave for two minutes, and then we’re out of here!”

“Yes, yes”, Sebastian replied defensively, “Anyway, anyone can leave whenever they wish...”

“That’s odd”, Kim disclosed quietly as he studied one section of the cave wall, “this dent in the rock here appears to be from a bullet...”

This immediately captured everyone’s attention and the two other males also took a close look.

“Well this appears to be a spent cartridge shell”, Jonathan said, as he stooped over and picked up something from the cave floor and adjusting his rimless glasses studied it very closely.

“It’s from a ‘303’, a Second World War rifle”, Kim concluded confidently.

“Hmm... let’s go outside and look at it under natural sunlight”, Sebastian said with some hesitation as he headed for the exit that was marked by the two sticks.

“Why would someone want to fire at a cave wall anyway?” Kim wondered as Sebastian reached the exit and collided with it.

“Ouch!” Sebastian gasped and staggered back holding his bloodied forehead. Everyone blinked and immediately Jonathon went for the exit with his arms outstretched.

“What’s this?” he demanded as he bounced off the cave wall as well, “It’s solid as a rock!”

Cathy and Yvonne glanced furiously at the three males as Kim started running his hands around the cave. Everything was as hard as rock.

“Where’s the exit? It’s gone!” Cathy screamed as they all started frantically touching the cave wall, “We’re trapped!”

“What should I do?” Yvonne whispered urgently to Sebastian as she patted her hanky chief on the gash that was causing blood to trickle down his worried face, “I’m supposed to be your guide.”

Sebastian’s eyes rolled back, the cave started spinning, his legs went to jelly and he fainted. The strange echo of Cathy saying, ‘what a hero...’ was the last thing Sebastian heard as he slumped to the ground.

Cool water splashing on Sebastian’s face caused his eyes to blink, flutter then open to reveal Yvonne’s smiling face over him.

“He’s coming to!” Yvonne said aloud, “Sebastian, hullo, are you alright?” she asked sympathetically as her hand gracefully dabbed a wet cloth over his brow, “You’ve been unconscious for over an hour...”

Sebastian started to think more clearly. He realised he was lying down on the floor of the cave with a backpack under his head. He began to recall the situation they had found themselves in.

“We’re still inside the cave”, Sebastian muttered, “Didn’t you find the exit?” Kim emerged deeper from inside the cave with Cathy.

“No Sebastian, we haven’t found a way out”, Cathy said with an air of mystery, “But this cave goes a fair way and Yvonne thinks it might lead to another exit.”

“Yes, there are caves in Uluru, and some go in at one place and come out at another... I’ve heard”, Yvonne explained, “So maybe this is just one long cave. I can’t be sure though”, she continued, her eyes searching the ground for words as Sebastian sat up and looked around.

“We tried the mobile phone but there was ‘no network coverage’”, Jonathon lamented as he held up Harrison’s mobile, “But that’s hardly surprising since we’re encased in rock...”

“Well I feel okay now”, Sebastian said getting to his feet and concealing his abject disillusionment, “So all we can do is walk along this cave, I guess...”

“What occurs to me”, Kim mentioned in passing, “Is that this cave seems to be manmade...”

It was a comment that began a train of thought and they soon noticed he was right. It was almost a perfect cave, even though it was still arkosic sandstone. It stayed the same height and width all the way they hiked, and it didn’t have any particular roughness or craggy sections a cave usually has.

And then there was this low light all the time, as if the surface of the walls gave off a light, not bright, like sunlight, but certainly light enough for everyone to see clearly.

“Hmm... It’s 5 p.m. now”, Said Jonathon looking at his watch, “They’ll be waiting for us at the base of Uluru...”

“I’ll be in so much trouble”, Yvonne bemoaned, “Regardless of whether it’s my fault or not.”

“It’s no one’s fault”, Cathy responded, “We’re all to blame for walking into this thing.”

“Have you noticed this cave is becoming spherical and it’s getting smoother and silvery in colour?” Kim mentioned, almost philosophically, as he ran his fingers along the surface.

They all did the same thing and noticed it was looking less like a cave every kilometre they covered.

“Sshh!” Yvonne said, “Can you hear that?” Everyone stopped and listened intently. “It sounds like a didgeridoo for crying out loud!” The sound of the didgeridoo echoed along the cave.

“We must be near an exit!” Sebastian concluded, “There must be a carroborree of some sort!”

“We’ll be home in time for dinner!”, Jonathon exclaimed as the group ran along growing more excited. The deep resonating noise of the didgeridoo became increasingly louder. Finally, they rounded another bend in the tunnel and ran into a large room.

“What is this?” Cathy exclaimed in confusion. They stopped and looked around in bewilderment.

“It’s some sort of television cube”, Kim offered in explanation as they looked at a television set in the middle of the room with a screen on every side of it.

“Maybe its some sort of foyer to an exclusive hotel”, Sebastian suggested as they all inspected the room more closely.

The television cube screened an aborigine sitting in the outback scrub playing a didjeridoo and the sound emanated clearly from the television.

“This is so familiar to me”, Yvonne said confidently as she studied the indigenous artwork on the walls, “It’s a story from our Dreamtime, handed down over many generations from the Pitjantjatjara and Yankunytjatjara tribes who own the area around Uluru, the Anangu people”, she explained as her eyes scanned the cave art.

“The old hairy man holds a large bark shield and painted on it are the symbols of all the tribes around Arnhem Land showing unity”, Yvonne said pointing to the first piece of art.

The sound of the aborigine playing the didjeridoo resonated in the background as Yvonne moved onto the next painting on the wall.

“... But the Diprofodon and Genyornis, large ancient animals, grab the shield and run into a cave, and this work here shows the old man tell his two sons to chase them and bring it back”, Yvonne explained to them as the group sat down and listened.

“On their journey they stop at a waterhole, and then they notice the roof of the cave is like the stars and the universe and the sky gods direct them to the place where they find the two ancient animals holding the shield and...” Yvonne’s voice trailed off.

“And what?” Cathy asked in anticipation.

“... And...” Yvonne’s voice faltered, “... And I don’t understand this final art work...”

“Well what do you think it may be?”, Jonathon urged.

“Don’t know... Possibly it shows they are given a choice or something”, Yvonne concluded with an air of vagueness, “Look, I’m a guide, not some brilliant indigenous art historian”, she protested.

“Okay, okay”, Sebastian responded quickly in sympathy, “You’ve explained a lot already. That’s great, really.”

“Incidentally”, Jonathon inquired, “What type of animals are a Dipro-thing and a Geny-whats-you-call-it?”

“Oh!” Yvonne’s eyes brightened, “a Diprofodon is a giant kangaroo, about 3 metres high, and a Genyornis is a giant emu. You see it’s all myths and legends passed down from my ancestor spirits.”

Cathy decided to take a photo and grabbed her camera from her backpack. She stood back from the group who were seated in a semi-circle with the television cube next to them and Yvonne standing in the background with the aboriginal paintings behind her.

“Smile”, Cathy whispered as she pressed the shutter and the flash momentarily illuminated the large room. There was a moment of reflection by everyone and then a strange thing happened.

A peel of thunder was heard from the television cube a few seconds after the flash of the camera. Everyone looked at the aborigine playing his didjeridoo in the vast red sandy plains of the outback and it began to rain on him.

He kept playing but this coincidence of Cathy’s camera flash followed by thunder and rain on the television image caused the group to look at each other uneasily.

“Well I think we should move on”, Sebastian said breaking the silence, “Maybe the cave exit is just around the next bend”, he suggested optimistically.

“Did you notice that these indigenous paintings are almost luminous?” Kim observed as he tapped the surface, “They’re not painted on as such, they seem like neon signs...”

“I know”, Yvonne nodded in agreement, “It’s quite odd really.” Zara, the dingo pup began barking at the television cube then scampered into the tunnel on the other side of the large room.

The group picked up their backpacks and followed her and as they ventured along the tunnel again the sound of the didjeridoo slowly faded into the distance.

Chapter Three

Slipping and Sliding

The tunnel seemed to be endless. The temperature was pleasant enough for walking and the light, though slightly dull, was easily bright enough to see by since the walls gave off a mysterious silvery glow.

“This walking is getting easier by the minute”, Jonathon noticed as he adjusted his rimless glasses, “In fact it feels like we are going down hill...”

“... And the surface is getting shinier”, Cathy added, “It’s as if we’re walking inside a large stainless steel tube of some sort”, she concluded.

Ahead of them the dingo pup began to slide along and then Yvonne, whose shoes had very little tread, also began to slide occasionally.

“Wow... oh!” Yvonne exclaimed as she lost balance and slipped over, “This is like walking on ice...”

“Hold on”, Sebastian warned, “This tunnel is descending more and more!” He also slipped over, and soon after the others all tumbled on their tails and began to slide.

“It’s like a water slide!” Jonathon said with an edge of excitement, “Maybe we should hold hands so we don’t get separated.”

“Yes, yes”, urged Sebastian as he grabbed Yvonne’s hand, “Let’s keep together. This is so weird.”

They soon caught up to the dingo and Cathy reached forward and lifted the pup onto her lap as they all whizzed down the shiny tunnel getting faster and faster.

This peculiar sensation of sliding was almost magical since the feeling was so smooth. It was also exhilarating. Kim reached into his backpack and pulled out his laptop computer.

“I think I can calculate how far we’ve travelled”, Kim replied as he tapped away on his laptop. It was moderately tricky because they were all speeding down a tunnel with arms linked.

“It must be around supper time and we’ve still got lots of sandwiches”, Cathy announced as she manoeuvred some plastic bags around and broke off some bread and fed it to the dingo pup.

“According to the step counter I have attached to my ankle”, Kim said as he studied the figures on the counter, “I estimate we walked about 17 kilometres today from the entrance of the rock to the spot we started sliding.” Kim made some more calculations.

“... And according to the compass I’ve had recording the direction we’ve travelled the whole time, we have been going north, slightly north-east, on average.”

“Are you sure this compass in your laptop is accurate?” Sebastian asked suspiciously, “Remembering we’re below solid rock...”

“Who knows what the magnetic force is like down here?” Kim answered belatedly, “So I could be completely wrong, but I think we’re about midway between Uluru and The Olga’s.”

“What on earth are you doing now?” Yvonne asked in surprise as Kim dangled his mouse from the laptop and pressed it against the wall of the tunnel as they sped down it.

“For some weeks I’ve been doing a test on how fast my mouse moves on my computer pad when I’m at home”, Kim explained, “And I’ve connected a tiny speedometer to the ball in the mouse.”

“... And so by running it along the wall you think you can estimate the speed we are going?” Jonathon probed in admiration.

“Yes, that’s right”, Kim replied studying the figures on the screen of his laptop, “And right now it shows we are travelling along at 120 kilometres an hour!”

“Well that’s what it feels like”, Sebastian said with his hair blown back rigidly. In fact they all had a similar hairstyle now from the speed they were going including the dingo pup whose tiny wind swept ears were now pointed horizontally backwards.

“Here Kim, have a tuna sandwich”, Cathy said pushing the sandwich into his mouth, “You’re so clever”, she continued with an expression of high esteem.

“... And there’s more”, Kim mumbled with a mouthful of sandwich, “If I combine our speed with our direction from the compass”, as he tapped a solitary key defiantly.

“... There! It says we are approximately 850 metres under the ground going downhill at an angle of 40 degrees and still heading in a north, north-easterly direction.”

“I feel great!” Yvonne called out loudly, “This slide is wonderful”. They all nodded in agreement as they whizzed along at break neck speed.

Jonathon began to fall asleep. One by one the others started to doze off with their heads resting on each other’s

shoulders or backpacks. Kim closed his laptop and also fell asleep.

Occasionally the dingo pup looked up at attention, as if she was on honorary guard duty, but then put her head back into Cathy's lap.

"... 'Only in extraordinary states of consciousness can one be aware of, or attuned to, the inner dreaming' ..." Yvonne whispered into Sebastian's ear. Her eyes then closed and all of them were asleep in this strange tunnel speeding along ever so smoothly.

Chapter Four

Think Tank

Jonathon's deep sleep was unsettled by the strange sound of a tinny harpsichord playing 'Waltzing Matilda' Rapid eye movement preceded his eyes blinking open and he looked at his watch that was sounding the alarm and switched it off.

"Oh, it's 7 a.m.", he said as he began to stretch in the confined position with his arms linked to the others. He elbowed some of the others, "We're slowing down!"

Everyone began to sit up and look around. They were still speeding along, but the gradient appeared to be levelling out.

"... Hmmm, we've slept for over 8 hours", Kim said, "We must have travelled a long way."

"I know one thing for sure", Jonathon responded, "Uluru will be crawling with search parties by now."

The tunnel was definitely levelling out and suddenly it became completely flat and they all stopped sliding. The dingo pup jumped out of Cathy's lap and started sniffing around. Everyone stood up and did some stretches.

"Okay then, let's start walking for a bit and then stop for breakfast", Sebastian suggested as they put on their backpacks and began strolling along.

"We've got enough food and water for a couple of days", Cathy estimated, "And then who knows...?"

The floor of the tunnel became a bit rougher and they got a good grip for walking, but it was still a tunnel with a silvery colour.

They hiked for about ten minutes and after going around a long curve they suddenly stopped in disbelief.

“It’s a World War Two Japanese military tank!” Kim exclaimed in surprise, “What’s it doing here?”

It was about the size of a land cruiser and was in pristine condition. Sebastian knocked his knuckles on the solid steel exterior making a clunking sound that echoed down the tunnel.

“Hullo? Anyone inside?” Sebastian inquired in trepidation, “We are here in peace.”

“...’We are here in peace?’...” Jonathon repeated in mock scorn.

“Well?” Sebastian replied defensively, “Inside might be one of those Japanese soldiers from the Imperial Army who doesn’t know the Second World War is over.”

Nothing happened. Soon they all began examining it more closely and Jonathon and Kim climbed onto it and tried to open the circular metal door on top that was firmly fixed shut. Kim had a considerable knowledge of Japanese culture and the Second World War in particular.

“Look at this everyone”, Kim said using his penknife to remove some sand from the corners of the metal tread. “It’s a mixture of red sand and arkosic sandstone.” He held out his hand and Jonathon adjusted his rimless glasses and inspected it closely.

“What’s arkosic sandstone?” he inquired.

“It’s what Uluru is made of”, Kim explained patiently, “And it means that maybe this tank came down the same tunnel.”

“Oh. I see”, Jonathon nodded.

“Smile everyone”, Cathy ordered as she readied her camera to capture the scene.

At that moment the metal door on top of the tank suddenly swung open and the smiling face of a Japanese boy popped up and Cathy snapped a photo showing everyone looking surprised.

“Hullo! I’m Charlie...” the boy blurted out almost defensively.

“We’re friendly visitors”, Sebastian said immediately and gave a courteous bow.

“I know you are”, Charlie responded with a more confident smile. He climbed out of the small round metal hatch and stood on top of the tank. “Do you want to come with me?”

“Yes, of course”, Sebastian replied shaking his hand. “Where are you taking us?”

“To meet my parents”, the boy said excitedly as he jumped onto the ground. Everyone glanced at each other and shrugged their shoulders in agreement.

“Sure”, Cathy complied quickly wanting to make the boy at ease. “My name is Cathy. This is Yvonne, our guide, and Sebastian, Jonathon and Kim.”

“We’ve been on holiday in Central Australia”, Sebastian explained.

“Oh... Well I’ve never been to Central Australia”, Charlie told them, “But I know all about it... and the big rock, Uluru...”

“Well Charlie, show us the way”, Sebastian said as he scratched his head momentarily and then picked up his backpack as they all started walking.

“How old are you Charlie?” Cathy inquired taking him by the hand.

“I’m 8 years old and I have an older sister”, Charlie explained enthusiastically. They only walked about fifty metres around a slight bend in the tunnel before they reached the exit.

A most unbelievable view opened out in front of them and they all stood motionless as their collective breath was taken away.

“This is so beautiful”, Jonathon muttered in amazement, “It’s unreal!”

They stood atop of a rise that was covered by an almond tree orchard in full blossom. Further down the hill was a large traditional Japanese village nestled next to a calm lake that stretched as far as the eye could see.

“And look at the sky!” Kim exclaimed gazing up in astonishment, “It’s like the universe set in stone!”

The roof of the enormous cave was about 500 metres above them and various illuminated rocks dotted the ceiling like stars and these acted as bright lights twinkling over the vista and creating daylight.

“Okay then Charlie”, Sebastian said, “Let’s meet your parents.”

They began descending a perfectly manicured path through the white blossom trees towards the village. They could see people going about their daily routines, working in their gardens and shopping at a market in the middle of the village.

Others were riding on their bicycles and a number of small fishing boats floated calmly near a small jetty.

“How long have you lived here for Charlie?” Kim asked with an air of nonchalance.

“My family have been here for over 60 years”, the boy answered. “It’s like a paradise for me.”

Chapter Five

The Formal Tea Ceremony

Charlie's mother shuffled into the room dressed elegantly in her silk white Kimono holding a tray of ceramic cups and teapots. Everyone sat quietly on the tatami mats with their legs crossed around a low wooden table.

"We rarely have formal tea ceremonies these days", she said placing the tray on the table, "But this is clearly a special occasion."

"We didn't know what to expect", Sebastian replied, "And as you can imagine, we've been through quite a journey."

"Ah... here is my husband now", she said in a relieved tone as Charlie's father slid open the rice paper door and entered with a smile.

"Hullo and welcome... I'm Charlie's father, Bepo", he said eagerly shaking everyone's hands and bowing courteously. "Please feel free to eat up these delicacies my wife has prepared, you must be hungry."

"Well we only had enough food and water for one more day", Cathy said as she chose a crispy tempura and ate it. "Hmmm, this is delicious."

"After this tea I will show you to your rooms", he outlined, "Where you can freshen up and relax with an ofuro..."

"That's a hot bath", Kim whispered to the others.

"... Then my father would like to invite you all to his place for an official dinner", Bepo said. "He is very old, but quite lucid really", he confessed as he passed around the platter of delicacies.

“I’m a skilled practitioner at serving cha-no-yu, or hot water for tea”, Charlie’s mother explained as she added some powdered green tea. “It’s a traditional ritual influenced by Zen Buddhism... although usually we’re happy with Lipton’s.”

“I see...” Sebastian observed and then looked directly at Bepo. “So, do you have a phone here so I can ring my parents?”

“A phone?” Bepo replied with a surprise. “Here? We’re miles under Central Australia! No, but don’t worry, you’re quite safe.” He then broke into spontaneous laughter.

“... But we have families who are worried!” Cathy protested causing Bepo to nod in sympathy.

“Okay. My father will explain everything over dinner”, he reassured them all. “Just relax and freshen up. Please, trust me.”

The group realised there wasn’t much to be gained by arguing so they continued with the formal tea party and ate as many of the delicacies as they could.

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After about fifteen minutes Charlie’s mother concluded the tea ceremony and they all stood up, thanked her and bowed. Charlie excitedly showed them to their rooms, which were located on the other side of a large courtyard.

“Wow! This is five star!” Yvonne said walking around the large guest room, “And look at this private courtyard, it’s so beautiful” she observed admiring the bonsai and shaped shrubs amongst the raked pattern pebbles.

“Oh look”, Sebastian commented as he reached for the remote control, “A digital television set.” He switched it on and a cricket match flickered on between Australia and

India. No sooner had Sebastian sat down on the sofa bed than their door was flung open and Jonathon called out.

“Sebastian! Quick!” he whispered urgently, “My room has a television! It’s showing today’s cricket live! ... Oh...” He said looking at Sebastian’s television, “You know.”

“Switch to channel 3, it’s the news”, Kim said entering the room. Sebastian fumbled with the remote control and soon found the news.

“... And search parties have found no sign of the missing students from Melbourne who have vanished completely on a walk around the base of Ayers Rock yesterday”, the newsreader announced.

“Well this proves we’re not dreaming”, Jonathan commented.

“Shoosh!” Cathy ordered as they all crowded around the television.

“... We cross live now to the crime scene”, the newsreader said turning to the screen beside him with another reporter standing next to Uluru. “... We believe a hanky chief has been found belonging to one of the missing students?”

“Yes, that’s right”, the reporter said. Behind him were the two sticks leaning against the rock wall and Cathy’s white hanky chief. “... This hanky chief, with Catherine Swift’s name on it, was found here and I’ve got with me the ranger from Uluru-Kata Tjuta National Park who was first on the scene... can you tell us about these footprints?”

“Yes”, replied the stocky ranger with a ruddy face. “We’re pretty much 100% certain that these shoe prints match the runners being worn by the missing students and the aboriginal guide”, He articulated, “But the interesting thing is they stop facing the rock as if they have approached the

rock face then climbed it”, he explained gesturing up the rock.

“... But the rock wall is too steep to climb isn’t it?” the reporter inquired.

“That’s correct”, the ranger nodded, “And that is the mystery of it all and why it’s being treated as a homicide.”

“We’ll bring you updates from the scene when they arise”, the newsreader said, “... In the meantime, here is the finance news...”

“Our parents will be horrified!” Cathy lamented as she turned to the others.

“There’s still no mobile coverage, so this doesn’t work”, Kim said closing the mobile phone and putting it in his pocket. “Try that phone”, he suggested pointing at the telephone next to the bed. Jonathan immediately grabbed the handset and tapped out some numbers.

“It’s ringing!” he said in surprise. Everyone looked at him. “Hullo? Who is this?” Jonathan asked urgently. “Oh. It’s you Charlie... I see... yes... thanks.” Jonathan put the handset down. “You can only make outgoing calls to other houses around the village, Charlie told me...”

They all stood silently for a while. Eventually Sebastian changed the TV back to the cricket. Everyone drifted back to his or her guest rooms leaving Sebastian alone.

“Well, I may as well freshen up, I guess...” he said to himself as he strolled into the bathroom and began running the bath. Sebastian turned on the bathhouse music and the gentle sound of the dulcimer and lute, the Koto, filled the room.

‘This is the most luxurious onsen I have ever seen’, he thought as he enjoyed the feeling of well-being and harmony.

Chapter Six

Wadaiko

Everyone sat quietly with their legs crossed on the tatami matting around a low wooden table. At the head of the table sat Charlie's grandfather dressed almost regally in his uniform of the Japanese Imperial Army.

The low sound of Wadaiko drumming from the surround stereo in the background gave an air of suspense.

"I propose a toast to our Australian guests", the grandfather announced as he held up a small glass of Sake. "Here's cheers."

"Cheers", they all responded in unison as they politely sipped.

"Hmm... this sake blends an earthy dry, yet delicate flavour", Sebastian replied nodding to the grandfather. At the other end of the table sat the grandmother dressed in an emerald satin Houmongi, or kimono, with gold edging and ribbon.

"My son and daughter-in-law have spent all afternoon preparing this banquet", she confided to Cathy, "And Charlie wants to be the waiter."

"Your menu's", Charlie announced as he entered the large dining room in a dinner suit clutching a bundle of folders with his hair brushed back. He smiled broadly as he handed them to the guests one by one. The grandfather began a story.

"In March, 1942, I was flying with the Zero fighters of the Chitose Air Corps, but our mission was not to bomb Darwin", the grandfather explained to the dinner guests, "Instead five of our fighters had tanks hanging below our

planes and we flew well into the interior of the Northern Territory and dropped them.”

“Didn’t the tanks get damaged when you dropped them?” Kim inquired in disbelief.

“No”, the grandfather replied raising his eyebrows, “... Some landed on their sides and we had to roll them upright, but they landed on trees or soft red ochre sand, and they all worked fine”, he confirmed looking at everyone in the eye. “Who produces the best cars now?” He asked with a wry expression.

“You do, I mean the Japanese do”, Sebastian concluded quickly in agreement.

“Everyone in our large planes, except the pilots, parachuted down and joined the tanks”, the grandfather described. “The planes flew back to the airbase in New Guinea and we drove the tanks to Ayers Rock. All of this was done under the cover of night...”

“Let our guests choose their meals”, the grandmother interjected. “Charlie! Take their orders.” Charlie produced a pad and pen and stood poised at attention behind Cathy.

“Let’s see,” she said scanning the choices, “Um... I’ll have the chicken on bamboo skewers with Yakitori sauce and spring onions, please”, she decided as Charlie scribbled away, “What will you have Sebastian, the Tonkotsu Noodle Soup?”

“Yes, yes”, Sebastian replied slightly startled, “With blanched snow peas and two poached eggs, please Charlie.”

“We’ll have the Maki-Zushi, rolled sushi, please, and seaweed spread with rice”, Jonathon requested on behalf of Kim and himself.

“Oh!” Yvonne said nervously realising everyone was looking at her, “Um, I’ll have what Cathy has...”

“The usual Charlie, raw fish and Sushi-Meshi, the vinegared rice”, The grandfather gestured impatiently. Charlie finished scribbling into his note pad and disappeared out the door.

“... We were on a secret mission and we had instructions directly from The Emperor to capture the heart of your country, Uluru”, he said thumping his clenched fist softly on the table and shaking the sake in the glasses.

“So, your convoy of five tanks made it to Ayers Rock?” Sebastian asked as he closed his menu and looked at the grandfather.

“Yes. There was no one to stop us but a small tribe of aborigines, some Anangu people, locals”, he said glancing sympathetically at Yvonne who avoided his eye contact, “So we captured them without force.”

“You had no resistance at all?” Kim inquired tapping his fingers on the dinner table in time with the background beating of the Japanese drum, the Wadaiko.

“No. On the contrary”, the grandfather announced with an air of excitement, “Two truckloads of white people arrived on the scene, armed. They were local stockmen and their wives, not soldiers, but they had sighted our tanks and they new about the bombings in Darwin and added two and two together.”

“What happened then?” Sebastian asked in amazement. The grandfather picked up his glass of sake and threw it into his mouth, gulping it down in one action, then rolled the glass along the table.

“There was a full moon and this illuminated the night”, he explained as everyone around the table listened carefully. The grandfather flashed back to the time in 1943.

‘... The convoy of five Japanese tanks rumbled along noisily with the soldiers running behind herding fifteen aboriginal prisoners handcuffed together. Glancing back they could see the headlights of the two Australian trucks in pursuit.

“Keep close to the rock!” the Commander ordered in Japanese to his soldiers, “We might lose them.”

The front truck bounced up and down over the broken shrubs and trees left by the tanks and the driver called Wally, a tough stockman with his wife seated alongside, was yelling to the men standing in the back of the truck.

“Hold on tight! We’re gaining on these people”, he barked with a rasping voice, “Take a pot shot!”

One of the men put his shotgun to his shoulder and pointed it towards the Japanese tank that could be vaguely seen through the moonlit dust. He fired and a bullet pinged off the rear of the tank.

The commander looked around quickly and yelled out some more instructions.

“Tell the front two tanks to circle round behind them!” he commanded. Two tanks swerved away from the rock, and snapping trees and branches in their path, they rumbled away into the darkness.

“This beats wild boar hunting!” Wally barked in the truck as they continued to gain on the Japanese tanks.

“Okay. Let them have it”, the commander ordered. Suddenly the rear tanks left tread went into reverse and the Jap tank turned on a sixpence, rotating 190 degrees, and

stopped, directly facing the oncoming trucks. “Fire once”, the commander ordered calmly.

“Jump!” Wally yelled as everyone leaped out of the trucks on seeing the looming confrontation.

The tank fired and hit the truck blowing it to pieces as the petrol ignited causing a secondary explosion. This fireball in turn set alight trees and shrubs nearby causing a bright glow in the immediate area.

“Get out of here”, Wally yelled to the second truck as it began to reverse and turn.

In the confusion the aboriginal prisoners of war broke away from the Japanese tanks and soldiers and shuffled into the night scrub towards the rock still cuffed together and seemed to vanish into thin air.

The driver of the rear truck managed to turn his vehicle and was about to slam his foot on the accelerator when his headlights shone on two Jap tanks stopped silently in front of him.

“Oh dear”, the driver lamented, “We’ve had it mate”, he said to the passenger.

They clambered out with their hands in the air and were soon surrounded by soldiers. One pointed his flamethrower at the second truck and fired engulfing it in flames and igniting the petrol tank causing another fireball.

“You are all prisoners of war!” the commander addressed the captured Australians. “We have formally taken control of Ayers Rock in the name of the Emperor of Japan!”

“Over my dead body”, Wally replied.

“If that’s what you want”, the commander yelled angrily, “Place him against the rock and prepare the firing squad!”

Wally, the truck driver, was blindfolded and stood up against the rock face of Uluru. Under the light of a full moon and spot fires burning around them the commander strode around boasting of his victory.

“I have a better idea”, he announced in broken English, “I will run you through instead!” he said laughing as he raised his bayonet and began running at the blindfolded truck driver.

The Australian shook his head enough to dislodge his blindfold and he caught sight of the moon reflecting off the shiny blade of the bayonet coming towards him and at the last moment stepped aside expecting to hear a ‘clunk’ as the bayonet hit the rock.

To everyone’s amazement the Japanese commander disappeared into the rock as if it was thin air.

Inside the cave the 15 aborigines hid cuffed together and laughed when the commander emerged from the rock. He looked around in confusion and fired a shot that ricocheted off part of the cave wall. Then he ran outside again.

“What sort of rock is this?” he demanded to know. “Drive a tank into it!” A tank turned around and drove towards the rock and then disappeared into the rock. The commander scratched his head and convened an urgent meeting with some of his soldiers.

“Maybe this tunnel hides lots of Australian soldiers”, he concluded, “We must invade it and take them out.”

At this point he screamed a lot of orders at his soldiers and before long the entire convoy of tanks, the Japanese soldiers and the Australian prisoners of war entered the rock.

Inside they recaptured the aborigines without any resistance and the Japanese Imperial Army set off along the tunnel. On finding no end to it they turned back, but the exit had sealed up. In frustration the commander fired more bullets into the cave wall, but they just ricocheted off the solid rock...’

The flash back concluded and the students sat silently around the table.

“Is this one of your bullets?” Kim asked placing the bullet he had found on the table.

“Yes, that is my bullet”, the grandfather replied after he put on his glasses and inspected it.

“Well 60 years ago you must have found the same hole in the rock as we did”, Sebastian suggested as Charlie and his parents entered the dining room with plates of Japanese cuisine.

“Hmmm. Smells delicious! I’m famished”, Jonathon said as he fumbled with his chopsticks.

“Enjoy!” the grandfather replied, “And help yourself to more sake”, as everyone proceeded to eat.

“Incidentally”, Yvonne inquired casually, “Did you come across a large cavern with a TV set in the middle of it in the tunnel?”

“Did we?” the grandfather recalled laughing, “I was driving the front tank and I crashed into it! My tank was dented, but not a scratch on the television cube.”

“Was there an aborigine playing a didjerido on it?” Yvonne replied enthusiastically.

“As a matter of fact, yes”, he said watching Yvonne closely, “And so we decided to release the aborigines from their

chains and they proceeded to perform a corroboree. It was quite fantastic.”

“So that television cube was there 60 years ago?” Kim asked.

“Yes, and none of us had never even heard of a television, let alone a television cube”, the grandfather responded scratching his head. “We simply thought the Australians must be an incredibly advanced nation, except the Australian prisoners of war we held hadn’t seen one either”, he concluded, “So it was all very strange.”

“And then your convoy of tanks, soldiers and prisoners, started sliding, right?” Sebastian probed more deeply.

“Indeed we did”, the grandfather nodded as he scooped more steamed rice onto his ceramic dish, “And we all came out where you did, except there wasn’t any village, only some aboriginal tribes.”

“What?” Yvonne uttered dropping her chopsticks. “There were aboriginal tribes already here?” she said in surprise.

“Yes. Apparently they had come down the tunnel hundreds of years ago”, he continued as everyone around the table went silent, “And settled here. They were pleased to see the aboriginal prisoners we had since they were all Anangu people from the same tribe.”

Yvonne’s face transformed from surprise to a mild smirk as the others looked at her proudly. But then she frowned and glared at the grandfather.

“So where are they now?” she demanded to know.

“Well their descendents are living in huts up the other end of this village”, Charlie’s grandfather replied in a matter of fact tone, “And the Australian families are there too”. He

continued gesturing innocently, “And the truck driver I tried to bayonet... he’s over 90 years old now.”

Can you believe the TV News

“This sake is too strong”, Kim said with a mildly slurred speech as he lay sprawled out on the sofa with the others sitting around watching the television.

Jonathan had the remote control and he was surfing the channels in search of the news. Charlie entered the room with a tray of coffee and after dinner mints.

“Good man, Charlie”, Cathy said eagerly, “Exactly what we need. Sit down and join us.”

Everyone suddenly looked at the TV as Jonathon located the ABC and a currents affairs programme had started.

“... The mystery disappearance of four students and their guide in the Uluru-Kata Tjuta National Park has continued to grip the attention of the nation”, the compere said, “But this mystery has deeper implications since one of the students, Kim Strong, is one of Australia’s most gifted students specialising in computer technology and mathematics...”

“That’s me!” Kim said sitting up abruptly and gazing at a recent photograph of him on TV, “I’m famous now...”

“Shoosh Kim, just listen!” Sebastian insisted as he snatched the remote control from Jonathon and turned up the volume.

“... I have with me here in the Canberra studio the Federal Minister for Telecommunications and the Attorney General”, the compere announced as they both nodded. “But first this afternoon I spoke to Kim’s parents...”

The compere sat back in his chair and addressed a large screen that showed Kim's parents seated together in a TV studio.

"My parent's!" Kim exclaimed.

"Thank you for agreeing to talk to us Professor and Mrs. Strong under these unfortunate circumstances..." They both nodded. "Firstly, do you have anything you would like to say if your son Kim is watching?" the compere asked.

"Yes", the father said leaning forward. "Please Kim, please contact us if you can, any way you can. We want you home."

"We have been told that he carried with him a very advanced laptop computer... can you tell us anything about it?" The compere inquired.

"Well yes", the professor said adjusting his glasses. "It's a specially modified one for his specific studies, it was supplied by the government because of his exceptional talent", Kim's father explained looking down and searching for words.

"I see..." the compere continued, "... And Mrs. Strong, did your son give you any indication that he might have his own plans...?"

"What do you mean, 'his own plans'?" She suddenly became very agitated and began yelling, "What are you suggesting? My son tells me everything! What sort of holidays do you conduct in Central Australia! I want my son back!"

"I'm sure we're doing the best we can", the compere said gesturing in apology. "Thank you for your time."

“Minister, what is your reaction to Mrs. Strong’s criticism?” The compere asked as the programme returned to Canberra.

“Well, I can assure the Professor and his wife that the Northern Territory police, and the rangers at Uluru-Kata Tjuta National Park are doing their best”, he said uneasily. “And I can assure the public that the government is taking this very, very seriously.”

“Is it true that this computer Kim has with him has a navigational tracking chip attached to it, and it shows that the laptop is somewhere inside Ayers Rock?” The compere asked.

“Now listen here!” the Minister interjected angrily, “This is only hearsay and rumour”, he continued glancing uncomfortably.

“Well Attorney General?”

“Well if it shows such a thing”, the Attorney General replied cautiously, “It must be faulty equipment. Uluru is made of solid rock I believe.”

“I mean there are some caves”, the Minister suggested evasively, “But they have all been carefully explored.”

“Okay then”, the compere concluded. “Thank you both and I’m sure this story has a long way to travel yet”, he continued turning to the camera, “And now to finance... A conference of chartered accountants in Adelaide...”

“So? Does your laptop have a tracking chip, Kim?” Sebastian asked as he turned down the volume of the TV and looked at Kim.

“Yes! I’ve told you already, my laptop has just about everything”, Kim offered innocently and openly. “I’ve got nothing to hide...”

The slightly tense conversation was interrupted by a knock on the guest room door. Yvonne stood up and opened it to reveal a very old Australian man standing there with a walking stick.

“Hullo. I’m Wally”, he said with his hand outstretched and the lines in his face creasing into a smile. “I’m the stockman from Alice Springs... I’ve been watching you all on TV.”

“Oh”, Yvonne responded shaking his hand, “Come in, I’m Yvonne Makepeace, the guide.”

“Hi. I’m Sebastian. Charlie’s grandfather just told us all about you”, Sebastian said as he walked across to him and shook his hand.

“Did he now?” he muttered sitting down. “It was his stupid decision 60 years ago that put us all down here.”

“You mean to go into the tunnel like we did?” Sebastian replied in sympathy.

“Yes. You see there is nothing wrong with this place... in fact it’s like a 5 star resort, and we can get whatever we want”, Wally explained in an old gravelly voice, “But there’s no sun! We don’t have sunshine. God I miss the sun. We’re in a huge underground cavern...”

Cathy poured him a cup of coffee. They all sat around as he told them about life underground. And Wally knew all about it because he had been there for over 60 years.

“Hasn’t anyone tried to escape?” Kim finally asked.

“Escape?” Wally barked back in surprise, “You don’t need to escape; you can just ask to leave. And of the few hundred people living down here, several have left...” His voice trailed off.

“How?” Kim inquired.

“Well, they’ll take you back to Hawaii. But then you never see them again.” Wally looked at everyone in the room and everyone looked back in a confused way.

“Hawaii? What has Hawaii got to do with all of this?” Cathy snapped back impatiently. “Oh, I’m sorry Wally”, she continued realising her disrespect. “I don’t understand.”

“Okay”, Wally said with a tone of resignation, “It’s like this... we have this settlement here of about a few hundred men, women and children, Australian, Japanese and aborigines”, he explained glancing at Yvonne, “And we’re on the banks of an enormous lake of pure water... but way over there is an island we call Hawaii.”

“Are they friendly?” Sebastian optimistically inquired.

“‘Business-like’ is how we describe them”, Wally answered, glancing up at everyone through his bushy eyebrows, “And they deliver us anything we want. For example, back in 1956 we asked for television and we all got black and white televisions.”

“So you ask these business-like Hawaiians if you want to leave, is that it?” Kim responded in puzzlement.

“Yes, exactly like that”, Wally said, “And they take you to their island and we never see you again.”

“Oh...” Sebastian frowned, “... And do they kill you?”

“No. Not as far as we can detect. We believe you go on a journey...” Wally explained interlocking his hands, “But where to, we don’t know...”

“Never to return here though?” Sebastian continued probing.

“That’s right. Nonetheless you move on”, old Wally concluded and then sat back in the sofa, “... And so that’s that.”

Everyone sat in silence. The dingo pup suddenly leaped onto Wally's lap and made herself comfortable. The silence continued.

"So how come you have a sun tan Wally if there's no sun?" Yvonne inquired innocently breaking the ice and easing the mysterious tension in the guest room.

"Well if you study the ceiling of this enormous cavern you will notice it's made up of all types of amazing stones. During the daytime they are very bright, creating daylight. When the sun sets above ground the stones darken leaving some that twinkle like stars, creating night time..." Wally explained making the answer so simple. "Also each house here has a solarium, which helps."

"Oh I see", Yvonne replied nodding her head.

"Anyway", Wally said getting to his feet, "Why don't you join my son and daughter-in-law and grand kids for a bar-b-que lunch tomorrow? If you think this traditional Japanese house is good, you should see ours!" He remarked boastfully.

"Yes, of course", Sebastian replied happily, "We would love to."

Wally leant on his walking stick and began shuffling out the door. Sebastian helped him as he made his way to a motorised golf buggy parked outside the house.

"I get about in this a lot", Wally said proudly as he began to climb into the drivers seat. Once settled he turned the ignition key and it started humming and he looked into Sebastian's eyes.

"If I was you and your friends", he said in an old rasping voice of advice, "I wouldn't stay here... I would try the

journey..." His eye's blinked a lot and he suddenly clutched his chest in surprise.

"Wally? Wally? What's wrong?" Sebastian said urgently as Wally's eyes widened momentarily and then shut tight. Sebastian quickly dragged Wally out of the buggy and laid him on the raked pebble path and started pumping his heart.

"Hey, help! Jonathon! Kim!" He yelled out. Within seconds the others crowded around the old man stretched out on the ground. Charlie's father appeared on the scene.

"Help me place him in the buggy", he ordered urgently as he climbed into the drivers seat, "I'll take him to our hospital!"

Within minutes they had reached a small modern hospital in the middle of the village but Wally was dead on arrival.

"We've feared this day for a long time", the doctor said quietly to the students sitting anxiously in the waiting room. "I'm afraid he's had a bad heart condition for some years. You did the best you could."

The five teenagers moped around looking confused. The young doctor walked with them to the door. There wasn't anything more they could do, especially under these circumstances.

"Incidentally", the doctor said with a smile, "Welcome to our village. It's good to see you down here."

Chapter Eight

The Funeral

The next morning the ceiling of the enormous cavern slowly became lighter. Kim sat at the window of his guest room looking out at the huge dead calm lake as the others slept.

Far away over the lake a hovercraft came into view. It slowly came closer until finally it gracefully hovered onto the white pebble beach and stopped.

Some neatly dressed men unloaded an empty coffin that was picked up by a few of the villagers and carried away towards the morgue next to the hospital. Several bouquets of flowers were also handed over.

The propeller on the hovercraft began spinning and it slowly turned around and hovered onto the water and powered away into the distance.

The phone rang in Kim's room next to the bed. Sebastian, Jonathon and Kim had all slept together in the large comfortable guest room and Sebastian reached over to the table and answered it.

"Hullo...?"

"It's Wally's son here", a voice said on the other end.

Sebastian sat on the edge of the bed nodding and agreeing with Wally's son. Finally he hung up and looked at Kim and Jonathan.

"The funeral is this afternoon in the village church and I've been asked to give a reading", Sebastian said looking a bit

surprised, “And we’re all invited to the wake instead of the bar-b-que Wally had arranged...”

Charlie and his mother appeared at the door carrying some suits and black dresses on coat hangers.

“We asked around some of the village students your size and borrowed these suits for the service”, Charlie’s mother said hanging them in the wardrobe, “I hope they are okay.”

That afternoon the small church was completely packed with just about everyone in the village and the rest sat outside. Wally’s coffin rested in front of the altar covered in flowers and the organ pipes above reverberated a slow mournful tune.

“Everybody seems to be looking at us”, Cathy whispered to Sebastian as they took their places in a pew near the front. Yvonne chose to sit with a group of aborigines further to the side of the church and most of the Japanese sat at the back.

The Minister, a young man dressed in robes, spoke kindly of Wally and explained how he had always been regarded as the village elder. The congregation sang some hymns and Sebastian gave a reading.

The Minister then called for a plate to be handed around and a collection was made followed by another hymn and then the eulogy was recited.

Finally the coffin was lifted onto the shoulders of eight relatives and friends of Wally and carried slowly down the aisle and out of the church.

Sebastian and Jonathan remained behind in the church. It was a traditional Christian church with colourful stained glass windows and a statue of Christ on the crucifix on the wall.

They noticed a half open door leading to a small room and they peered in to see a group of villagers counting the money from the collection.

“They keep detailed books”, Jonathon whispered to Sebastian as they looked at a long table with books, ledgers and calculators scattered over it.

The villagers inside this room were almost gleefully filling in all the figures in precise detail. One of them glanced up to see Sebastian and Jonathan watching them.

“We love getting all the books to balance exactly”, the fellow said enthusiastically with a smile.

“Does it require such major book keeping?” Jonathan inquired adjusting his rimless glasses.

“Yes! Of course!” they stipulated firmly.

“Oh, okay then...” Jonathan responded innocently realising the intrusion, “Keep up the good accounting”, he said with an uneasy smile.

The funeral procession meandered quietly through the village and up to the immaculately kept cemetery. A lot of the headstones had Japanese calligraphy on them and all the villagers who had passed on seemed to be buried in the one cemetery.

“This view is so picturesque”, Kim whispered to Cathy as she in turn was politely smiling to a few Japanese students who had manoeuvred themselves nearby.

“Excuse me, are you Kim?” a young Japanese woman said quietly to Kim. The Minister recited the last rites as Wally’s coffin was lowered into the grave.

“Yes I am”, Kim responded in surprise, “Why do you ask?”

“My name is Arsami. I saw you on TV last night, and I was wondering if I could show you around our university?” she asked politely with her eyebrows raised. Family members threw some flowers onto the coffin and everyone had moist eyes.

“Yes, of course, I would be delighted”, Kim whispered in response. It hadn’t occurred to him that this village would have an actual university, but nothing really surprised Kim now, not least this unexpected invitation.

The burial service finished and all those present ambled away as the gravedigger shovelled dirt into the grave. The Australian contingent, including Sebastian, Jonathan and Cathy, made their way to Wally’s house where the wake was to be held.

Yvonne wandered off with the aborigines as they had their own traditional burial ceremonies planned. The Japanese went about their daily routine since they felt rather awkward stemming from the fact that 60 years ago Wally had tried to prevent the Japanese Imperial Army from capturing the heart of Australia, Uluru, in the first place.

“If it wasn’t for my grandfathers misguided patriotism we wouldn’t all be stuck somewhere way under the Northern Territory”, Arsami said to Kim as they strolled along the drive towards the deserted university campus. “We closed the university today because of the funeral”, she explained.

Before long they reached some modern buildings and Arsami showed Kim a few of the small lecture theatres and they stopped in the library.

“This is certainly a comprehensive library”, Kim said as he reached for a book in the science fiction section. “May I borrow this one?”

“Yes, of course. I’ll just stamp it at the desk”, Arsami said as she wrote down the book title and Kim’s name. “Journey to the Centre of the Earth by Jules Verne”, she said looking curiously at Kim. “I’m majoring in space exploration.”

They left the library and strolled into a large courtyard that was filled with plumb trees in full bloom with sweet scented pink blossom on show. A mesh covered it and a fine rain sprayed down making their formal clothes damp.

“Welcome to ‘The Secret Garden’”, Arsami said taking Kim to the middle where a square water sculpture created a thin sheet of water cascading off the sides. “This is the most secluded spot we have”, she explained proudly, “And it can only be used by the students.”

“It looks like a bed!” Kim said with a half smile.

“Yes, that’s what the sculptor imagined”, she replied as a dense fog immersed from the overhead mesh, “And various climates encase it.” Soon the misty fog became so condensed that they couldn’t see each other.

“I suppose you don’t get any change in the weather down here”, Kim said quietly seeing nothing and hearing only water dripping.

A few minutes later the fog began to dissipate slightly revealing Arsami through the mist.

“Do you want to go to Hawaii tomorrow...?” Arsami whispered to Kim. “You might never return...”

On the outskirts of the village far below the sparkling stones the Anangu tribesmen danced around the large fire. Yvonne sat both exhausted and exhilarated by the traditional ceremony of mourning and stared into the

flames of the fire as some of Wally's clothes continued to burn.

The sound of the didjeridoo and the wood sticks clacking echoed out over the clam lake. Sitting next to Yvonne was the eldest aborigine who was too old to dance but had a lot to say to new visitor.

"I was 16 years old when Japanese soldiers captured me", he said as he used a stick to draw a long snake in the sand, "And I thought they must be ancestral spirits because when we escaped along the side of Uluru it opened up and we went in the rock."

"Had this ever happened before?" Yvonne inquired.

"No, not in my lifetime. But a Dreamtime story told of a long snake that the Pitjantjatjara and Yankunytjatjara people walked into", he explained as he ran the stick down the middle of the snake, "And they never came out."

"Maybe this story was about the original aborigines that found the tunnel?" Yvonne suggested.

"Yes. Because when we slid down the long tunnel and came out over there", he said pointing his stick at the mouth of the tunnel on the other side of the village, "... There was nothing here but a tribe of aborigines who told us they had lived down here for as long as they could remember."

"... But they were Anangu people?" she asked.

"Yes, and pleased to see us", the elder said happily, "Because we gave them new ideas", he explained, "And made their lives more interesting, plus things like the radio..."

"Did you miss your life around Uluru?" Yvonne inquired.

“Yes, especially my wife who was pregnant. So I never got to see my baby because of the soldiers”, he said stabbing the snake with his stick in the sand.

“What is your name then?”

“John Makepeace.”

“Really?” Yvonne said in surprise, “Because my name is Makepeace, Yvonne Makepeace. So you must be my great grandfather!”

There was a silence for a time. A few other aborigines sitting nearby looked at them both.

“My wife must have had a boy then”, the elder said looking into Yvonne’s eyes.

“Do you remember that elder playing the didjereedo on the television when you first went into the tunnel?” Yvonne inquired, almost discreetly.

“Do I? ‘The tank stacked into it!’” the elder said laughing gruffly, “And do you know who he was?”

“Who?”

“My great grandfather, because I recognised the inscriptions on the didjeridoo”, the elder related proudly, “It said Makepeace!” At this point all the aborigines started laughing and resumed their dancing.

Yvonne pondered the whole story and then her mind drifted to the responsibility she felt towards her students since she was supposed to be their guide, ‘Not that it matters down here anyway’, she thought to herself.

Chapter Nine

Water skiing behind the Hovercraft

The knocking on the guest room door didn't help Sebastian's hangover and Jonathon's snoring next to him made it worse.

"Sebastian, are you asleep?" Kim whispered loudly.

"What?" Sebastian asked, "What time is it?"

"6 a.m. and I have a hovercraft", Kim whispered.

"So what?" Jonathan interjected, also waking up.

"So we can go to Hawaii", Kim announced as he collected his computer and backpack.

"You mean this minute?" Sebastian replied sitting up and rubbing his eyes.

"Meet Charlie's older sister, Arsami", Kim said proudly, "She's got the use of the hovercraft and is taking us on a tour of the lake."

Before long the traditional breakfast ceremony was underway with everyone seated cross-legged on the tatami mats around the low wooden table.

The prescribed gestures and phrases expected of guests at a formal traditional Japanese breakfast soon got dispensed with as soft-boiled eggs and crispy tempura were passed around.

"How deep is this lake?" Jonathon inquired as he scooped up some Maki-Zushi, rolled sushi, and seaweed spread.

"Very deep", Arsami replied, "But as far as we know it's quite safe", she continued with a mild smirk crossing her face.

“There’s something about you all on the morning telly”, Charlie announced innocently as he bounded into the dining room and switched on the television. They all turned around to watch in momentary silence.

“... Hopes are fading for the four Melbourne students and their guide who went missing in mysterious circumstances three days ago in the Uluru-Kata Tjuta National Park”, the compere lamented, “... And in further developments the parents of the Melbourne students have mounted their own search party.”

There was a reaction of mixed disbelief around the breakfast table as they saw shots of their parents climbing out of a convoy of land rovers next to the rock. Sebastian’s father appeared on the screen looking calm but concerned.

“I know that the rangers and Northern Territory Police are doing their best”, he said looking up at the rock, “But we’re also going to start searching...”

“There won’t be room to move around Uluru”, Yvonne responded.

“... Rumours and gossip are rife throughout Australia, however, after it was revealed that a bus load of Japanese tourists claimed their tour bus hit a dingo on the road next to Uluru and they were the last people to see the students who were standing nearby”, the compere continued with an intriguing expression, “And the driver of the tour bus speaks to us now live from the base of Uluru...”

“You claim a dingo ran out in front of your bus?”

“Yes. I swerved to miss it, but it changed direction and I couldn’t avoid it”, he said as the camera followed him into the scrub next to the road, “And here is the dead dingo right here”, he said pointing to the ground as the camera panned down to see the bloodied dingo lying on it’s side.

Zara, the dingo's pup, made a mournful yelp as she watched the TV image and proceeded to put her tiny paws over her eyes.

"Oh, you poor little darling", Cathy cried in sympathy and picked up Zara and stroked her tenderly.

"... So there we have it", the compere said blithely, "... A classic Australian drama of four missing students and a dead dingo. And now to other news; book keepers in Brisbane have threatened to walk out..."

"Oh switch it off!" Cathy demanded and turned to the others, "I can't see how they'll find the entrance to the tunnel if it's solid rock."

"If only we could send a message to our parents somehow", Jonathon said as they all looked at Kim.

"Well don't look at me!" Kim protested, "I've tried everything I can."

Sebastian balanced knee deep in crystal clear water at the edge of the lake holding the towrope as Arsami sat in the driver's seat of the large hovercraft with everyone else on board watching with amusement.

"Okay..." Sebastian called as Arsami pushed the throttle forward and the hovercraft powered away with Sebastian skilfully jumping and weaving to and thro on a single ski across the wake caused by the boat.

"One of the redeeming features of life down here in this enormous cavern", Arsami yelled to Kim over the sound of the whirling propeller, "Is we have a great time really!"

The dingo pup sat contentedly on the front of the hovercraft with her tiny ears blown back by the breeze from the speed of the craft.

The village was soon a dot on the horizon and Sebastian let go the towrope and Arsami spun the hovercraft around and picked him up.

Subsequently they all had a water ski and eventually the propeller was stopped and they all sat around on the hovercraft as it floated listlessly on the flat expansive lake.

“I guess you never realised there was such a huge body of water under the surface of Australia”, Arsami said, “It’s perfectly safe”, she continued and then dived into the pure clean water and bobbed up smiling. Then everyone dived in after her.

“Are you quite certain this water is safe?” Jonathan inquired treading water nervously, “I mean we can’t even see the bottom of this lake...”

“Look, in all the time here we’ve never had a problem”, Arsami reassured them as she swam further away from the hovercraft, as some dolphins emerged from the water in graceful unison.

The pup started barking. Suddenly a huge Blue Whale broke the surface of the still water only metres away.

“GET OUT!” Jonathon yelled as he thrashed around in terror. The whale then submerged itself with its tale crashing onto the surface of the water before disappearing.

“Arsami! It’s dangerous!” Sebastian called out angrily.

“Relax. It’s a robot. We built it”, she replied calmly paddling around.

“That’s real”, Sebastian responded in disbelief.

“... So whales can sing can they now?” she replied sarcastically, “... Just listen.”

The Blue Whale emerged again, but this time it opened its enormous mouth and sang, 'To dream the impossible dream...' in a perfect male tenor voice before going under again.

"Now I've really seen everything!" Cathy snapped back as she and the others swam back to the hovercraft with Arsami laughing aloud in the water.

They all clambered on board with their body language belying someone who has suffered a frightening practical joke.

"Hey listen..." Arsami pleaded apologetically as she finally climbed back onto the hovercraft dripping with water, "It is a robot you see? We can get anything from Hawaii and some of the guys ordered all the components necessary to build a robot whale", she explained realising the scare they all had, "And they built it. It's been swimming around for years... Completely harmless... True."

"Well... I guess it's possible", Kim replied trying to defend Arsami's honour, "... It seems anything is possible here after all..."

The incident focussed their attention on the issue of this so-called island they referred to as Hawaii and a long discussion soon climaxed into a heated argument.

"It's your fault Kim for going into the rock in the first place!" Cathy accused Kim.

"My fault? You found the hole!" Kim barked back angrily at Cathy causing the pup to shelter in her arms.

"Look, it's no one's fault. The point is we're here, now!" Sebastian interjected.

"You can talk!" Cathy yelled back at Sebastian, "You're the idiot who talked us out of walking over the rock."

“She’s right Sebastian”, Jonathan chimed in, “And if we hadn’t listened to you we wouldn’t be in this mess.”

“Well it’s not a mess”, Arsami rejected quickly, “It’s a paradise.”

“What sort of place is a paradise you can’t leave?” Jonathan responded logically.

“Anyway, you can leave. You can go to the island”, Arsami said.

“But then what?” Cathy snapped at Arsami, “You said no one ever comes back! Didn’t you!”

“Look, why don’t we visit Hawaii now?” Kim suggested looking at Arsami. Everyone thought for a moment in silence. Zara began wagging her tail.

“Yeah! Why not?” Jonathan replied in a tone of reconciliation.

“Are you sure it’s safe?” Sebastian asked Arsami.

“Yes! It’s safe!” she replied emphatically but avoided eye contact with Sebastian. Cathy was quick to notice this.

“... And?” Cathy inquired.

“And what, Cathy?” Arsami replied defensively.

“Well? Why didn’t you tell us this in the first place Arsami?” Cathy cross-examined Arsami with a suspicious tone.

“Oh all right then! It really is a paradise...” Arsami revealed in a stilted voice, “... Especially if you’re a chartered accountant.”

“A chartered accountant?” Jonathan responded laughing out aloud.

“... So how long will it take us to get to this island?” Sebastian inquired scratching his head.

“A few hours at full speed”, Arsami answered.

“Okay then, let’s go!” Sebastian suggested and everyone agreed although with an air of mysterious unease.

Arsami climbed into the driver’s seat of the boat and turned the ignition and the large propeller began whizzing around and in a matter of seconds the hovercraft was speeding across the dead calm surface of the lake.

Chapter Ten

Hawaii

“I can see an island”, Sebastian called out to Arsami over the noise of the propeller.

“Yep. That’s it”, she replied and glanced at Kim sitting next to her.

Slowly the island loomed up in front of them. It was quite large with palm trees and hotels and villas dotted around the place and golden sand around the edge.

“If it wasn’t for the rock ceiling high above us”, Jonathon said looking up, “We could be in the South Pacific.”

As they got closer to the island they could see people lying on the beaches and swimming. Yvonne leaned over the edge of the hovercraft and studied the turquoise water watching some sea turtles breast stroking by.

“It looks like we’re getting the official welcome”, Arsami observed as a group of people congregated on the beach and the hovercraft slowed to a crawl then hovered up the beach and stopped.

A group of Polynesian women with grass skirts approached them smiling a warm aloha and holding a colourful lei of fresh flowers.

Everyone stepped off the hovercraft onto the beach and the women placed the lei’s around the necks of the visitors and a middle-aged man in a white suit held out his hand.

“Hullo. Welcome to our island, I’m Stan”, he said in a friendly way, “You must be Sebastian”.

“Yes”, Sebastian replied slightly taken aback, “How did you know?”

“I’ve watched your story unfold on the TV”, he continued smiling, “You’ve all been on quite an adventure...”

“Look over there”, Kim commented quietly to Arsami, “There’s an escalator on the beach!” he observed as they all noticed the same thing.

“Well don’t take that”, Arsami laughed, “You’ll never come back...” The escalator went down into the beach and holidaymakers ascended and descended from it.

When they started walking up the beach they heard some yelping. It was the dingo pup standing alone on the hovercraft.

Cathy strolled back to pick her up but before her hands could grasp the pup she leaped off the hovercraft onto the sand and scurried up the beach and disappeared down the escalator.

“Stop! You can’t go there!” Stan ordered as Cathy instinctively ran after the pup. She stepped onto the escalator and began running down after it.

“Zara! Here girl!” she called without looking around. Finally she caught up with the pup and grabbed her. “Got you...”

Sebastian came bounding down the stairs after her and they all reached the base of the first escalator together.

“Oh good, you got her”, Sebastian said breathlessly, “Let’s go up now”, he continued as they stepped onto the ascending escalator.

As they went up Sebastian looked over the edge of the moving hand rest and his eyes widened in disbelief.

“What’s wrong?” Cathy inquired as she stroked the panting pup and also peered over the edge, “Oh...”

Cathy grabbed her camera and grasping Zara in one hand and her camera in the other she snapped an amazing photo. They soon reached the top and stepped off the escalator onto the beach.

“Okay then, you got your puppy back I’m glad to see”, Stan said with a scornful look. He continued gesturing towards the nearby hotel, “We have a special luau prepared for you all. May we proceed?”

“Yes of course”, Sebastian replied calmly, “This dingo pup has a mind of its own”, he confessed.

“What is a luau?” Cathy asked Sebastian under her breath.

“It’s a party that can go on for weeks”, he replied quietly as they strolled into the lobby of the hotel and were ushered into a lift.

“I thought you might like to freshen up before dinner”, Stan explained as the lift doors closed. They started going up and in a few seconds it stopped and the lift doors opened.

“We’ve given you all the penthouse suite”, Stan said. “Make yourselves at home and I’ll see you downstairs at 8.” The lift doors closed and the six of them were alone.

“Look at this!” Cathy announced as she took her digital camera out of her bag, flipped open the viewer and retrieved the picture she had just taken. They all crowded around her and stared in amazement.

“It looks like escalators in a department store”, Jonathon observed, “... Except endless.”

“Here, connect your digital camera to my screen”, Kim suggested as he got out his computer and opened the screen. Within seconds they had a large image of the photograph Cathy had just snapped from below the beach.

“How can there be so many escalators?” Sebastian pondered aloud, “They must go down 40 floors.”

Kim meanwhile tapped away on his keyboard as his laptop scanned and calculated the image and some numbers came up promptly.

“Not 40 floors... 450 floors!” he announced.

“What sort of island is this?” Yvonne asked with trepidation as she joined Sebastian who was inspecting the suite.

The penthouse was expansive and luxurious to the point of unreal opulence. Four plush bedrooms opened off the large living area and each one had a magnificent bathroom in white marble with gold fittings and a panoramic view of the beach and the lake below.

“Hey, check this out”, Jonathon called out as he discovered another room that was like a boardroom.

A large table surrounded by ten or so armchairs filled out the middle of it and there was a lectern, screens of various kinds and a bar. At one end was a huge television screen that covered the entire wall.

Kim picked up the remote control and fumbled around with the buttons until it flickered on.

“It’s my mother!” said Jonathon in surprise. It was a close-up of Jonathon’s mother on the television.

The camera cut to a wide angle and revealed a press conference in progress. Some of the student’s parents were seated behind a long table cluttered with clusters of microphones and tape recorders.

“This is a special programme coming live from Uluru-Kata Tjuta National Park”; the compere said speaking to the camera. “We’re conducting a live press conference here

with the missing student's parents as Uluru begins to change colour with a beautiful sunset behind us. Yes, a question over there..."

"My question is directed to Professor Strong", a reporter said, "... Now that you've witnessed the search in progress, are you satisfied everything is being done that is possible?"

"Yes, it's been very thorough", Kim's father replied to the reporter, "... But I believe that one student, Jonathan, has his teachers backpack..."

"That's right", the compere said, "And it contains various navigational instruments, compasses etcetera, that the tour guide wanted to show his students on top of Uluru... so what is your point Professor..."

"Doesn't that bag also contain the tour guides mobile phone", Kim's father said with his voice getting louder, "And it has a satellite tracking chip attached?"

"Well, I'm not aware of this fact", the compere replied frowning.

"... And it shows that the mobile phone was last detected inside this rock", the professor continued pointing behind him, "Along with my son's laptop?"

"Well this is only rumour and hearsay", the compere responded.

"Maybe so!", Sebastian's father rebutted swiftly, "But why is the government being so secretive about this? Either there are two separate tracking devices that show the same thing or not!"

"What's wrong with you all?" Kim's mother suddenly interjected angrily, "... They are inside the rock! Can't you see?" she said, banging her hand on the table repeatedly and

causing support from the other parents and consternation from the assembled press.

“Okay then”, the compere said trying to calm the situation, “We’ll have to leave this live press conference here...”

“Wow! Your mum doesn’t muck around!” Yvonne said looking at Kim across the boardroom table. Sebastian grabbed the remote control and switched off the large screen and it went blank.

“So Yvonne, do you think your elders will allow them to start drilling holes into Uluru in search of a tunnel?” Sebastian asked as they all looked at her.

“As if...” Yvonne replied rolling back her eyes. Everyone became quiet.

“... Any suggestions...?” Sebastian asked as he strummed his fingers on the varnished wooden surface and then reclined back into his comfortable armchair.

“Two things”, Cathy responded quickly, “We’re not dead ...yet, and all of this seems real...”

“Yes. That’s the strange thing”, Kim responded. “I think we should all go down the escalator together and see what’s there.”

“Well...” Arsami chimed in carefully, “I suspect once we go down there we can’t get out...”

“But I did”, Cathy snapped back.

“I know, but you only scratched the surface”, Arsami replied with irritation, “... As Kim pointed out, there must be 450 floors down there.”

“Anyway, I still think we should go down that escalator”, Kim suggested.

“Well when and how?” Jonathan asked.

“Tomorrow”, Sebastian replied, “And we should attend this dinner”, he continued, “And we might learn something more.”

“But don’t let on we have this plan”, Arsami warned. “None of us in the village new about these floors below the island. We all thought this was just an island we called Hawaii...”

“... And we don’t want to bite the hand that feeds us”, Cathy concluded staring at the dingo pup as it began licking Cathy’s fingers.

Chapter Eleven

Kalua Pig from the Irnu

“Welcome to ‘House of the Sun”, said Stan warmly, the middle aged man in the white suit, as the students stepped out of the lift into the exclusive restaurant. “This is the crème de la crème of eating places here in Hawaiï”, he continued smiling proudly.

“We’ve spent half the day water skiing, so we’re quite hungry actually”, Sebastian replied. “This place looks great”, he continued politely as waiters handed them all glasses of champagne.

The restaurant was quite crowded and noisy with a Tahitian rumba band bopping along amongst torches lighting up Polynesian belly dancers in grass skirts twisting and gyrating around a central stage that had a bright reddish yellow illuminated dance floor.

“This place is designed on the theme of a volcanic crater”, Stan explained ducking quickly as a blast of flame spitted from a fire blower dancing amongst the diners, “So it’s quite a hot place”, he laughed. “Anyway, help yourself to the buffet when you’re ready.”

They drifted away in different directions to enjoy the atmosphere and entertainment. The lighting was low and moody and the long buffet table was covered with various salads and food arrangements with tall candles illuminating the sculptured pineapples.

Cathy took a second take as she spotted Jonathan at the other side of the stage seated in a private compartment with

two Polynesians. A third one joined them with a tray of food.

“You’ll love this savoury Kalua pig”, she said to Jonathan as she grappled with tongs to place some on his plate. “It’s roasted in an underground oven called an Irnu.”

The four of them reclined comfortably into large colourful cushions around a bamboo table where some red, yellow and orange lanterns cast light into the dimly lit compartment.

Further over in a brighter area Sebastian, Yvonne and Cathy were seated with some couples they had never met. After some small talk Sebastian began to ask some important questions.

“Which department do you work in below?” he inquired casually avoiding eye contact with the conservatively but well dressed stranger.

“I’m just in filing and records”, he replied, “But after this holiday here I’ll move up 40 floors to auditing. What about you?”

Jonathan froze for a moment. He was speaking blind and didn’t want to reveal he wasn’t from the island. Cathy glanced at him and made a lightning nod.

“Oh.. I’m in cash flow”, he replied with nonchalance.

“Cash flow?” the stranger asked quizzically.

“Cash flow and financial advising”, Cathy interjected with a persuasive air.

“Ah... I see!” the stranger replied. “... Many floors below my department. Anyway, there are so many people working below”, he continued, “And everyone is dressed the same.”

The three students glanced at each other as they sipped on their glasses of champagne and then followed the antics of the fire dancer on the stage.

“Would you excuse us while we dance?” Sebastian asked as he took Yvonne’s hand and they strolled onto the dance floor. Cathy also excused herself and went into the women’s rest room.

“This is such an exotic place...” Yvonne said to Sebastian as they weaved their way around the crowded dance floor. “Where’s Jonathan going?” she whispered, gesturing over Sebastian’s shoulder. He glanced around to see Jonathan entering the lift with the three Polynesians he had been sitting with.

“Looks like he’s making the most of the Aloha Mai Tai greeting!” Sebastian replied laughing.

Cathy sat alone in the exquisite cubicle of the luxurious women’s rest room as she overheard a conversation between two women who were powdering their noses in front of the large mirror.

“... You mean you really got the promotion? Wow! Congratulations!” one said to the other.

“Yeah! I’ve been working so hard in the auditing department, so now it’s paid dividends”, she replied excitedly. “I take the train in a few days after my holiday finishes here.”

“Well I’ll leave you some of my mirror lipstick.”

“ Really? Thank you so much! That’s a First Class ticket!”

“What is your pigeon hole number..?”

“It’s 230. Room 230. Thanks heaps. I can’t wait to show it off on the ground floor station”, the other women replied as they both laughed and left the rest room.

‘... I wonder what mirror lipstick would look like on my lips?’ Cathy thought to herself. ‘...I’ve never heard of such a thing... glitter yes, silver yes, but not mirror... and where does this train go those women were talking about...?’

The six students all returned to the penthouse suite and sat down around a large coffee table alongside a wide window overlooking the beach and lake. Here they exchanged pieces of information they had gleaned from the party.

“I found out that on the ground floor is a railway station”, Cathy announced as she served the coffee.

“... Do you mean 450 flights down below this island?” Kim responded in surprise.

“Presumably”, Cathy said, “... And I guess it must go somewhere...”

“Well Yvonne and I chatted to some of the other guests”, Sebastian continued lowering his voice, “And it seems everyone at the party has something to do with finance.”

“I found out much the same thing”, Cathy said looking at Arsami.

“Don’t look at me!” Arsami replied indignantly. “I told you they were all a bunch of chartered accountants. It’s been common knowledge for years around the village”, she said.

“... And they all dress like them too!” Jonathan chimed in. “Speaking of which, look what I’ve got for you all...” He walked into his room and returned with several fawn coloured suits and dresses.

“How did you get these?” Kim asked as they examined them and Sebastian tried on a coat.

“It’s not what you know but whom you know”, Jonathan replied proudly as he also produced six smart fawn briefcases and satchels.

“... Maybe below us is some sort of giant secret multi national organisation”, Kim theorised, “and if we catch the train it will take us back to the surface.”

“Anything is possible, it seems”, Sebastian replied, “and I guess it’s feasible”, he continued stroking his chin, “and at least we would be moving on...”

“Well I for one don’t want to spend the rest of my life at the village”, Arsami said.

Sebastian stood up and looked out the large window and was joined by Jonathan. They peered up at the cavern ceiling hundreds of metres above them with the luminous rocks sparkling like stars. And below them on the beach they could see partygoers coming and going from the escalator.

“If we put our suits on in the morning and keep up a businesslike demeanour there’s no reason why we can’t just go down the escalator and catch the train”, Jonathan reasoned.

“What have we got to lose?” Sebastian responded.

“Let’s fill in our breakfast menu’s for, say, 9.30 am, so there’s nothing suspicious”, Kim suggested.

“... So is the plan we go to work tomorrow morning at 7 AM...?” Cathy asked around the room. Everyone nodded in agreement.

Chapter Twelve

Going Down

Yvonne was the first person to wake up the next morning. She walked into the main room and knocked quietly on the bedroom doors.

Everyone showered and put on their fawn suits and dresses and packed their belongings into the briefcases and satchels including sandwiches and fruit from the hotel fridge.

“... Okay, stay calm”, Sebastian instructed them all before leaving the room. “Think like businessmen, and stick to our plan”, he said as he pressed the lift button.

The lift doors opened and a man stood there in a luminous blue suit with cap. Their hearts missed a collective beat, but on closer inspection they looked down to realise he was holding a spray can and polishing rag and he was a hotel cleaner.

“Off to work early then?” he said smiling.

“Yes”, Jonathon chimed in calmly, “... someone needs to keep this organisation running smoothly”, he continued as he led the way into the lift and pressed the button marked Hotel Lobby.

The lift doors closed and they all stood in silence as the lift began to descend. It soon stopped again and the doors opened revealing an empty lobby except for another cleaner manoeuvring a bulky floor cleaner along with a hum.

“Have a good day”, Kim said politely to the cleaner in the lift as he continued polishing. They strolled confidently through the lobby and pressed their way around the high

rotating door and within a few steps they were on the beach.

“Just one minute”, Cathy said, “I have something to collect.” She turned around and strolled briskly back into the lobby. The others looked at each other uneasily.

“I have a parcel to pick up please”, Cathy said confidently as she approached the long Hotel counter and the attendant greeted her with a smile, “pigeon hole 230.”

“Yes, of course.” The young man turned around and scanned the small compartments with his finger and located 230 and pulled out a small parcel and gave it to Cathy. But as she placed it in her satchel there was a muted yelp.

‘Zara’s in my satchel!’ Cathy thought to herself. ‘Did the attendant hear that? I’ll cough...’ Cathy coughed trying to imitate the yelp. The young man smiled and Cathy turned around and walked away.

Before long she rejoined the others standing on the beach making small talk. Kim was gazing at the cavern ceiling hundreds of metres above them. It was becoming lighter in colour.

“What did you do?” Sebastian inquired in puzzlement, “Did you forget something?”

“I’ll tell you later. Let’s go”, Cathy replied. They all strolled along the beach towards the escalator. The beach was deserted except for a couple of cleaners in the distance who were picking up rubbish and raking the sand.

Once they reached the start of the escalator they didn’t hesitate but stepped onto it and began descending.

It was immediately brighter because of the artificial light. Nothing seemed to happen; no alarms began ringing. It was

surprisingly silent. Jonathan couldn't resist the temptation and took a quick glimpse over the side of the moving handrail.

"Seeing is believing!" he said to Sebastian, "its amazing... escalators going down as far as I could see!"

"So far so good", Sebastian replied as they reached the end of the first escalator and swung around 190 degrees and stepped onto the next. "Err, err", he corrected himself as they spotted a few businessmen coming up the escalator opposite.

The people loomed up towards them and they passed by with only Jonathan looking up for a moment and giving a polite nod. They reached the end of this escalator then stepped onto the next, and then the next, and the next, as they kept going down.

Occasionally they passed sealed doors or windows with the shutters closed. On one escalator, however, they began to hear the ambience of a crowd with the added noise of crockery and cutlery, which sounded like a cafeteria.

"This must be where everyone has breakfast before work", Cathy mentioned as the escalator descended into a huge dining area where a few hundred people sat and ate.

The same scene went for several floors and they estimated they had passed over a thousand people enjoying breakfast. The escalators became more busy as workers stepped on and off at different levels.

Everyone was dressed the same. After a while the floors became open workspaces with office partitions and hundreds of people sitting in front of computer screens with a buzz of activity and this went on for about fifty levels.

“I’ve been counting”, Yvonne announced, “we’ve passed two hundred floors just now!”

As they continued descending they felt more comfortable and became increasingly relaxed and chatted calmly, even joking and laughing with each other. Sometimes they walked down the moving steps and then just stood and descended smoothly.

“Don’t you get tired of cleaning escalators?” Jonathan inquired making small talk as they caught up to a couple of cleaners in luminous blue outfits polishing the handrails.

“Sick to death of it”, one cleaner answered with a smile, “but it’s a job.” Arsami looked carefully at the first cleaner and she returned the gaze as they exchanged lop-sided half smiles.

“Do you have nice sleeping quarters?” Arsami asked the women who looked in her forties.

“Oh yes, not bad”, she replied. Her Asian eyes belied a deep secret as a tear welled up, “... but not as good as yours.” Arsami grasped her hand and squeezed it gently.

“What do you do in your leisure hours?” Sebastian inquired as he noticed a sign of recognition between Arsami and the cleaner.

“See for yourself”, she gestured as the escalator began passing a floor with bowling alley’s, then swimming pools, tennis courts, and even an entire indoor park.

“Well let’s sit in the park for a moment”, Cathy suggested, “So Zara can stretch her legs.” They agreed and stepped off the escalator and strolled into the park leaving the cleaners to continue polishing.

The park was expansive with trees and shrubs around the perimeter and a jogging track meandering through it.

Yvonne opened her satchel and took out some sandwiches and drinks and they all sat down on the park benches. Cathy carefully lifted the pup out of her satchel and put her on the lawn where she pranced around happily.

“That cleaner is my sister-in-law...” Arsami whispered to the others, “and she escaped to this island 20 years ago and never returned...”

“Oh... I see”, Cathy replied sadly as she glanced over her shoulder at the cleaners on the escalator.

“To think that all this time she’s been working here as a cleaner and we never knew”, Arsami sighed.

“Well another few hundred floors and we’ll reach the train station”, Sebastian announced optimistically as he looked up to see some joggers approaching.

“What do you think you’re doing down here?” The jogger asked as he stopped next to them, puffing and sweating in a white singlet and runners. It was Stan, the host from the previous evening, the middle-aged man in a white suit.

“We got a job here”, Sebastian replied pursing his lips firmly, “.... And we start work today”, he continued bluffing as he shuffled his feet uncomfortably.

“I haven’t heard anything about this... the only job you’ll get down here is as cleaners”, Stan responded. “Now follow me and I’ll take you to your new quarters and you can begin training.”

The dingo pup stopped wagging her tail but then suddenly bounded away across the park and disappeared into the trees and shrubs.

“First get that dog!” Stan ordered. Cathy was soon in pursuit followed by the others. Behind one thicket of trees was a lift and the door was open.

“Pssst! Come here!” came a voice from the lift. Cathy looked over to see Arsami’s sister-in-law holding the pup and gesturing urgently.

“Over here!” Cathy called to the others as they frantically searched through the thick trees and finally located the lift and fled inside.

“STOP! I command you all to stop!” yelled Stan as he began running across the park waving his arms and yelling. However just as he got to the lift the door closed in his face so he sprinted back to the escalator and started descending.

Inside the lift everyone was breathless. Arsami’s sister-in-law pressed the button marked ‘Station – Ground Floor’ and the lift began going down.

“Thank god for you!” Arsami said as she hugged her sister-in-law, “it’s been 20 years and we’ve missed you so much... we thought you were dead.”

“Well working here as a cleaner is as good as!” she replied, “but hiding in this tradesmen’s lift isn’t the solution. How do you plan to get on the train when we reach the ground floor?”

“Good question”, Sebastian replied.

The tradesmen’s lift was quite spacious. In fact it even had chairs so everyone sat down. Kim studied the various buttons on the control panel and pressed ‘direct’ so it wouldn’t stop at any other levels on the way down.

“How long will it take to reach the ground floor?” Jonathan inquired.

“About 10 minutes... it’s a long way actually”, the sister-in-law replied as she held Arsami’s hand. They looked up at the numbers above the lift door as each one illuminated the further they descended, 240... 239... 238...

‘No lift will defeat me’, Stan thought to himself as he puffed and panted his way down the endless escalators. It was his job on

the line after all since he worked in security.

Inside the lift everyone sat in silence. The dingo pup was sniffing around the briefcases and satchels and eventually put her head inside Cathy’s satchel and took out a small parcel in her tiny jaws.

“Oh! I forgot about that!” Cathy remembered in surprise as she prised the parcel from the pup and unwrapped it. A small wooden box revealed itself and Cathy opened the lid to find several lipsticks. She rotated one and a mirror lipstick emerged.

“How did you get that?” Arsami’s sister-in-law gasped in disbelief, “... That’s your First Class ticket!”

“That’s what I heard”, Cathy responded proudly as she pursed her lips.

“What are you talking about?” Sebastian asked as Cathy began applying the lipstick. It glided onto her lips and covered them in mirror; crystal clear shiny mirror.

“Well you see, this mirror lipstick is like a ticket... you travel First Class on the train”, Arsami’s sister-in-law explained as she glanced up at the numbers above the lift door counting down, 21... 20... 19... 18...

“How do I look?” Cathy inquired innocuously as she smacked her lips and smiled.

“What about the guys?” Sebastian asked in a sorry tone.

“You can take a partner”, came the reply as Cathy handed the mirror lipstick to Yvonne and finally Arsami and they began applying it to their lips.

Meanwhile Stan was making fast progress on the escalators. He had only a few floors to go and although he was becoming severely fatigued he calculated he would be able to stop them taking the train in time and save his job.

4... 3... 2... Ground Floor... The lift stopped and the doors opened. Everyone stepped out looking apprehensive.

“Thank you”, Cathy said as she handed Arsami’s sister-in-law three mirror lipsticks, “have these.”

Arsami then hugged her sister-in-law closely, rubbing her hands up and down her luminous blue cleaning outfit. They looked at each other and then the lift door closed separating them once again as a tear ran down Arsami’s cheek onto her mirror lips.

The numbers above the lift went up a few floors and then they all turned away and began sprinting along the corridor to the entrance of the station.

“You’re cutting it a bit fine!” the ticket collector said as he glanced at the stunning mirror gloss on the lips of Cathy, Yvonne and Arsami. “Go straight through to the First Class carriages”, he said with a smile. The door opened and they all entered the station.

Just as the door closed Stan appeared breathlessly at the top of the final escalator. He came sprinting down it and ran along to the tradesmen’s lift and cramped with a stitch he stopped and watched the numbers above the lift door counting down, 3... 2... 1...

His eyes widened as the doors opened only to reveal an empty lift. With a frown of resignation he turned and sprinted along the corridor to the station entrance.

However his running slowed to a shuffle and with a mixture of puffing and panting Stan collapsed at the feet of the ticket collector and died of exhaustion.

The Mirror Station

“Will you reflect on this?” Jonathan observed as he breathed on his rimless glasses and cleaned them. They all stood silently in awe as they surveyed their reflections around the station made completely of mirrors. This sense of awe was coupled with an enormous feeling of relief.

“Every inch is a mirror!” Yvonne said in amazement, “I’ve never seen anything like it.”

Even the gleaming train in front of them had a mirror surface. They all stared at their reflections on the train and pondered their appearance. Their smart well-tailored fawn suits and briefcases made them look every bit the businessman and woman.

The station was huge. A few people at the other end of the mirror platform were lifting suitcases onto the train and some station attendants in silvery suits shuffled around preparing for the train to leave. One approached them.

“... Just had a jogger collapse and die outside the station”, the attendant informed them regretfully.

“Really?” Sebastian replied in muted surprise.

“Yeah. Evidently he was seen sprinting down the escalators from the park. He covered over 300 floors then just died.”

“Smile”, Cathy said, breaking the silence as she took a photo of their mirror image reflected on the train exterior.

“Well let’s get on board”, Sebastian suggested.

They strolled over the mirror tiles of the platform floor towards the train but couldn’t see any doors or windows. Everything was a mirror.

After a moment of confusion part of the mirror on the train slid aside revealing a waiter in a white tuxedo standing inside the carriage.

“Bonjour...” he said with a gracious nod, “my name is Marcel, and I will be looking after you all on this trip”, he said with a crisp French accent, “Please enter. The train is about to leave.”

“How long is this train trip?” Kim inquired.

“How long? You don’t know?” Marcel replied with a quizzical look. There was an awkward pause.

“How long... in hours and minutes”, Cathy interjected quickly blinking her eyes.

“Oh. I see! The precise time?” Marcel answered smiling, “54 hours and 40 minutes exactly, madam.”

They all looked at each other and Sebastian shrugged his shoulders and stepped onto the train and the others followed. At that moment there was a whistle blown, the carriage door closed and the train began to move very slowly.

Everyone gazed out the window in total admiration at the mirror station and watched as it disappeared out of sight and was replaced by a wall of shiny stainless steel.

The interior of the First Class carriage was lavish and everything was in various shades of white including the large sofas and armchairs.

“Well, we’re on the train”, Cathy said smiling as she placed the puppy on the pale carpet, “... we made it!” They all sat down and relaxed as the train hummed along smoothly.

“Anyway, when’s lunch? We’re famished!” Sebastian asked the waiter.

“When ever you are ready, Sir”, Marcel replied nodding, “in the dining carriage.”

They followed Marcel to the 5 star restaurant in the next carriage and a beautiful young waitress in traditional French lace passed them the menus.

“Une jeune et belle serveuse”, Marcel said with a smile as he lifted her short black dress, “I am sure your waitress will look after you or it will be waddy pat le drum stick with my baguette!” Marcel said laughing as he tapped his long bread stick onto her white lace panties, “... my little wand works wonders here!”

She giggled momentarily with her pen poised on the note pad to take their orders and smiled at Jonathan.

“Let’s see...” Jonathan said as he scanned the menu, “I’ll have the Cumin-dusted duck with a marmalade of girolles and papaya please. And what is the carriage red?”

“Carriage red?” Sebastian asked in puzzlement.

“Well? We’re on a train, so it wouldn’t be a house red”, he explained patiently.

“It’s the medium-bodied Chateau Blanc Ledger”, the waitress replied with a pleasant expression, “... a perfect partner for your gastronomic exploration here...”

“Speaking of exploration”, Kim said placing a book on the table, “I’ve got a copy here of ‘Journey to the Centre of the Earth’, by Jules Verne, which I’ve been reading”, he said flicking through the pages, “will our return to the surface be as dangerous as his adventurers?”

“Of course not!” Marcel protested almost in disgust at such a suggestion, “... you will return by rocket!”

“Rocket?” Cathy responded in bewilderment.

“Don’t forget you are wearing mirror lipstick!” Marcel said glancing at Cathy’s lips, “... it is the passport of elite travel.”

“Ah yes, I almost forgot”, Cathy muttered as she buried her eyes in the menu, “... hmm, I’ll have the Supremes de Volaille en Papillote please.”

The revelation of their method of travel took them all by surprise and the others quickly ordered their meals ranging from Quenelles, baked fish mousse to Ravier a la danoise, the Danish specialty. Marcel and the waitress smiled and left.

“According to the book by Jules Verne”, Kim explained in a low voice as everyone leaned over to listen, “some adventurers had an ancient map that showed the route to the centre of the earth and they followed it and returned on a raft that was propelled by an active volcano...”

“But this book is science fiction”, Sebastian mentioned.

“Exactly”, Kim replied, “and so far our journey seems to be real, I guess, so it makes sense that we would return by a rocket of some sort.”

“Seems terribly far fetched to me”, Cathy said as she poured a bowl of water for the dingo pup on the table.

“Well it might sound far fetched to you”, Arsami said breaking her long considered silence, “but I’ve spent 20 years living in the village underground and that wasn’t a dream. I can assure you it was real!”

“And let’s face it, if we hadn’t escaped the clutches of Stan we would now be undergoing training as cleaners!” Jonathan re-iterated firmly.

“And don’t forget my sister-in-law”, Arsami pointed out, “she has been a cleaner for 20 years!”

“Well, I guess so then...” Cathy said as her voice trailed off. Marcel entered the dining carriage with a bottle of red wine and proceeded to uncork and pour it.

“Anyway, I think we should celebrate”, Sebastian proposed, “since it looks like we’re going home.”

The glasses clinked together and the waitress arrived with the French cuisine and they ate the *delices de France*. The lunch meal meandered onto dinner and the celebration continued concluding with *crème fraiche* and caviar.

Finally after chocolate and coffee and a cognac all round everyone decided to stop brooding about their peculiar predicament and go to bed. Their First Class carriage had six opulent compartments containing double beds and en suite bathrooms.

Jonathan stayed up a while longer watching a classic French black and white movie, ‘The Hunch Back of Notre Dame’, on the large screen at the end of their carriage since there was no television.

“May I run your bath...?” came the whisper from behind Jonathan who turned around in surprise to see the French waitress standing there.

“Yes, please”, Jonathan responded as he sipped on a cognac.

Some time elapsed and Jonathan ambled along the carriage to his compartment. He could hear the tap running as he entered.

“Mon doit de pied est coince dans l’évier”, the waitress whimpered in distress as Jonathon entered the en suite bathroom.

“Oh dear. My French is only meagre”, he lamented, “... but it appears your toe is jammed in the bath plug hole.”

“Oui...” she whispered. “Can you pass me the soap crème?”

Jonathan carefully tugged on her foot and enough soap crème lubricated her toe and it came out but the release caused a domino reaction and they both slipped into the bath and Jonathan’s elbow knocked the tap causing the shower to cascade down on them.

“Tu es mieux que le bossu Notre Dame!” The waitress whispered as she allowed the bath to fill and reaching for the champagne in the nearby ice bucket she dimmed the lights.

“Je suis ton reve realise”, she again whispered, “voyage au centre de mon univers.” Jonathan translated it, as ‘I am your dream come true journey to the centre of my earth...’

The next morning there was a tap tap tap on each door and Marcel announced that breakfast was being served in the dining car. Une jeune et belle serveuse was back on duty giving preferential treatment to Jonathan and the continental breakfast lived up to the French culinary reputation.

The sumptuous meal drifted into lunch, which in turn meandered into another dinner celebration and everyone adjourned to bed like it was *de je vu* from the previous evening.

The next morning the tap tap tap was a bit firmer and Marcel announced that after breakfast the train would be arriving at the mirror station.

“The mirror station?” Sebastian repeated quizzically, “I thought we just left the mirror station?” Everyone sat in silence as they had their continental breakfast.

Occasionally they would look out the window to see if anything was different but the stainless steel tube continued to whiz by. However just as Marcel served a second round of tea and coffee the train began to slow down. Suddenly the mirror station came into view.

“Oh no... It’s the mirror station again!” Jonathan lamented.

“We must have gone in a giant circle or something”, Kim suggested as the train stopped.

“Well here you are”, Marcel announced with a smile.

“But it’s the mirror station again!” Cathy protested causing the waitress to laugh.

“Not so!” Marcel responded, “it’s a mirror image of the mirror station. It’s identical, that’s all.”

Everyone grabbed their possessions and stepped gingerly onto the mirror platform. They looked along the carriages to see a few hundred people alighting from the train.

“The first class transit lounge is through there”, Marcel said as he pointed towards a door, “have a wonderful journey back to the surface...”

The beautiful French waitress shed a tear as she said farewell to Jonathan and everyone stepped onto a conveyer belt walkway that took them along to the departure lounge.

Eventually they were ushered through a door by some friendly rocket attendants.

Chapter Fourteen

And we all shine on

“Hello. My name is Valentina”, a middle-aged women said to them all with a Russian accent as she glanced down at their mirror lipstick, “I am your escort for this leg of your trip.”

They were ushered on board into the first class compartment and asked to change into new red suits that were supplied and then they sat down in a double row of large comfortable seats and safety belts were fastened.

“Look! It’s a fish!” Sebastian said in surprise as he peered out his window seat porthole, “... are we in an ocean?”

“Da”, Valentina nodded, “deep in the Pacific Ocean... very deep.”

“Oh! And are we the only passengers on this craft?” Cathy enquired.

“Niyet”, Valentina answered, “the economy class is full, but you all have first class to yourselves”, she said as she handed out scented wet hand cloths and ear phones that had tiny microphones attached, “please put these on. We are taking off shortly.”

They all put their earphones on and discovered they could talk to each other and hear their responses. The compartment they sat in was spacious and modern.

“Greetings. This is your Captain speaking”, a deep voice suddenly announced that resonated through their earphones. “We have begun countdown and soon we will be at ignition stage. Please place your seats back to horizontal. Have a pleasant journey back to the surface.”

A deep rumble began to vibrate the compartment and slowly became louder. Everyone looked out their portholes and curious fish were swept away by a rush of smoky bubbles.

The noise got louder and louder and the bubbles turned to yellow and red like the seawater outside was on fire.

Finally there was a deafening blast and everyone felt compressed into his or her seats and they all experienced that strange sensation of ascending very fast.

"I can hardly breathe! My lungs feel so compacted", Jonathan gasped. The bubbles began streaking past the windows and the water went dark.

"Are we all okay?" Kim asked, "I feel terribly uncomfortable." Some of the others gave a nervous thumbs up except for Yvonne who appeared to be unconscious.

"Yvonne! Are you all right?" Sebastian said clutching her sweating hand. She began to blink her eyes and looked at Sebastian with a dream like expression.

"Wow!" she muttered, "Can you believe it...?"

"That's quite common when we blast off with such force", came the deep voice of the Captain again through their earphones.

"Oh dear!" Yvonne managed to utter in embarrassment, "Can you hear us?"

"Da!" he answered then laughed, "if you look out your windows you will see the surface in a moment."

"That soon...?" Sebastian asked looking around at the others.

The seawater became lighter and suddenly bright sunlight flooded into the compartment causing everyone to squint. After a moment of surprise they suddenly all broke into uproarious jubilation.

“We made it! We’re back!” came the euphoric cries all around the first class cabin with backslapping, hugging, kissing and applause.

They all gazed out the portholes at the ocean below them and the wonderful real sunshine beamed in onto their faces. Some clouds passed by and the view was terrific.

“Wow! What a scene!” Jonathan whooped loudly, “I wonder when we will land?”

“In three weeks”, came the deep voice through their earphones.

“WHAT?” Sebastian protested, “but that’s the surface there!” he replied to the Captain, “you said we were going to the surface!”

“The surface of Mars”, was the reply through their earphones.

“MARS?!” was the unanimous reply, “MARS!?”

“What are we going to Mars for?” Cathy yelled. Valentina looked around angrily from her seat further up the cabin.

“Excuse me! No yelling on this flight please!” she said tersely.

“But we were told we were returning to the surface!” Cathy continued in an angry tirade.

“We never said the surface of Earth”, the Captain’s voice announced, “we are returning home to Mars.”

“But this is absurd!” Sebastian protested loudly, “We want to go home to Australia!”

“Turn this thing around now!” Jonathan screamed.

“Now listen, calm down”, the deep voice of the Captain said almost in sympathy, “there’s no question of that”, he continued trying to reason with the uproar.

“DO SOMETHING SEBASTIAN! JONATHAN! KIM!” Cathy screamed with the veins around her eyes throbbing, “I demand to speak to you now Captain! In person!” Cathy ordered.

“... Well I’m afraid you can’t”, he replied apologetically, “But once we’re safely in orbit you can float up here and I’ll talk to you...” Yvonne began to cry and was soon joined by Cathy.

“Will you look at that? I can see Japan!” Arsami muttered in amazement, “... it’s beautiful.” She then remained mysteriously muted as she stared out the porthole.

Everyone went silent and gazed out the portholes in awe. The view of Earth was simply breathtaking and nothing could have prepared them for this experience.

“Australia...” Jonathan said under his breath, “Just look at Australia...”

“Would you like to watch some television?” Valentina chimed in as she pressed some buttons and at the front of the cabin a large screen flickered on, “we get fantastic reception up here as you can imagine.”

Everyone was too absorbed in the astonishing view of Earth to look up except for Kim.

“Isn’t that St. Paul’s Cathedral in Melbourne?” he asked quizzically. The others did a second take and stared at the screen. The sound came on clearly and they heard a hymn being sung, ‘The Lord’s My Shepherd’, and the image switched to a shot of the congregation.

“Hey! Hold on! There’s my family!” Cathy exclaimed in shock.

“And there’s Mum and Dad!” Sebastian mumbled in surprise, “they look like they’re at a funeral...”

“Those are big pictures of us in front of the altar surrounded by flowers”, Jonathan observed sombrely, “... It’s our funeral...”

A huge crowd of mourners filled St. Paul’s Cathedral and it spilled out onto the street. There was a large contingent of students and as the television camera slowly panned around the cathedral they could clearly see their friends, family and relatives.

‘Bip bip... bip, bip... bip, bip...’ came the sound of a mobile phone. At first no one noticed it. Then Kim began looking around.

“Isn’t that some one’s mobile?” Kim asked. The others noticed the faint ringing too.

“That’s coming from your briefcase Jonathan!” Sebastian announced, “Quick, get it.” Jonathan grabbed his fawn briefcase from under his seat and opened it and located the mobile phone.

“Yes! It’s Harrison’s mobile”, he said as his eyes widened, “look at all those text messages!”

“We must be in range again. Read them!” Kim said urgently.

‘THE SEARCH PARTY IS LOOKING FOR YOU GUYS’ Jonathan read out aloud.

“It’s dated last week when we went into Uluru”, Jonathan continued, “I’ll read another one...”

‘PLEASE RING HOME NOW’ ... is another. There’s about 50 text messages here and phone messages”, Jonathan said excitedly, “I’ll play one.” He pressed a few buttons on the mobile phone and placed it to the microphone on his head set.

‘It’s the Uluru-Kata Tjuta National Park Ranger here, where are you guys?’ The voice on the message stated, ‘You’re well overdue back here. Are you injured? Please return this call or call your parents.’

“Jonathan, ring someone NOW!” Sebastian ordered, “we might go out of range any moment.”

“Who? Who will I ring!” Jonathan replied in a panic.

“ANYONE!” the others shouted.

“But this is Harrison’s mobile. It hasn’t got any numbers I know”, Jonathan replied becoming agitated, “Hold on, I know my brothers mobile number, I’ll text message him!” he said as he tapped away quickly on the mobile phone and finally pressed send.

‘Bip, bip... bip, bip...’ sounded on his brothers mobile phone as he squirmed around in embarrassment and quickly took it out. Inside St. Paul’s Cathedral the Minister conducting the service was speaking about each of the students. A few pews back from the front sat Jonathan’s family.

“Turn off your mobile Philip now!” Jonathan’s father whispered angrily to Philip as he read the message.

‘WE ARE ALIVE. NOT DEAD.’ Philip read with surprise. He showed it to his father.

“But look dad... it says this!” Philip whispered back.

“It must be a crank! Turn it off I told you for heaven’s sake!” Jonathan’s father whispered tersely. Philip turned his back on his father and quietly tapped in a return message.

‘WHERE R U ?’ he wrote and pressed send.

“He’s replied!” Jonathan said in a loud voice. “He asks ‘where are we?’”

“Don’t waste time! RING HIM!” Sebastian responded. Jonathan pressed the right buttons and waited as everyone stared at him.

Philip’s mobile phone began ringing in the cathedral. He immediately pressed the answer button but at the same time his mother snatched the phone from him.

“Didn’t your hear what your father said?” Jonathan’s mother snapped back in an angry whisper.

“Just put it to your ear!” Philip urged. His mother rolled up her eyes but nevertheless put the mobile phone to her ear as the Minister continued talking to the congregation about the students.

“It’s ME! It’s ME, JONATHAN!” He shouted. His mother blinked her eyes in confusion and then raised her eyebrows and whispered into her husband’s ear.

“I’ve got Jonathan on the phone! It’s his voice!” she whispered to her husband almost hysterically. She then cupped her hand over the phone, “Johnny! It’s Mum! Are you all right darling?”

“Shhhh!” Other mourners whispered in the surrounding pews as they turned around and looked at Jonathan’s mother. Jonathan’s father grabbed the mobile.

“Jonathan? What on earth are you up to?” the father whispered into the phone putting his head down to avoid causing a scene, “we’re in the middle of your funeral son!”

“I know! We’re watching it on TV now!” Jonathan replied in excitement.

“Listen. Don’t hang up. I’m going outside son, don’t hang up”, Jonathan’s father whispered and then grabbed his wife’s hand and squeezed past Sebastian’s family in the same pew. “I’ve got Jonathan on the mobile, can you believe it?” he muttered to Sebastian’s father as he pushed by.

Jonathan’s father calmly searched for the nearest exit and led his wife out a side door of the Cathedral. The Minister looked up from the notes he was reading and watched them leave causing a murmur in the congregation.

“... Jonathan, in particular, had a vital sense of adventure”, the Minister told the mourners, “and was always the first to put his hand up when it came to a challenge...”

“They’ve walked out on my funeral...” Jonathan said to the others. “Are you there Mum? Dad?” he said into the mobile.

“Tell them we’re okay too”, Cathy said in disbelief.

“We’re outside”, Jonathan’s father said loudly, “I can talk properly now. Are the other’s with you son?”

“Yep. They’re fine too”, Jonathan replied with a building excitement, “you wouldn’t believe the time we’ve had!”

“Well where are you all?” his father demanded to know.

“We’re hundreds of kilometres above you dad!” Jonathan responded with a relieved laugh, “we’re in a rocket... hullo? Dad? Hullo...?”

“Jonathan! Hullo?” his father replied loudly in panic.

“It’s gone dead”, Jonathan lamented looking at the mobile and then the others, “No Network Coverage.”

“Dial again!” Sebastian suggested.

“You’ll be well out of range now”, Valentina called across to them enjoying the drama, “we’re travelling at over 50,000 miles an hour from earth now, sorry...”

“Bummer”, Sebastian replied, “but the television works...”

“Da. Much stronger signal”, Valentina explained with a smile, “... in fact you can watch any TV station on earth... a choice of thousands actually...”

“Oh...” Sebastian reacted by screwing up his face, “well let’s stick to the ABC... at least they’ve bothered to show our funeral live.”

For about an hour the students watched their service in St. Paul’s Cathedral. Occasionally they laughed or cried, or couldn’t decide whether to laugh or cry, or laughed and cried at the same time.

Arsami spent a lot of the time gazing out the window at Earth since she wasn’t included in the service.

Yvonne also felt a bit alienated because she thought she was somehow to blame for the whole thing in the first place being the guide for their hike around Uluru. They had all done their best to alleviate this feeling of guilt but Yvonne wasn’t convinced.

“We talked you into entering the rock Yvonne”, Sebastian commiserated, “It wasn’t your fault at all...”

“Yeah sure, sure”, she replied sarcastically, “what sort of Aboriginal guide leads you from the red centre to the red planet?”

And matters were made worse when the ABC showed a small demonstration outside the cathedral of students with placards demanding holes be drilled into Uluru in search of a tunnel.

Nonetheless, they were in outer space now and it seemed so real.

“My god, it’s full of stars!” Jonathan observed as he peered out the window, quoting Poole, the famous science fiction astronaut.

“Now your funeral is finished”, Valentina said as she watched the congregation file out of St. Paul’s Cathedral, “you can ascend to heaven”. She laughed and switched off the seatbelts light.

Chapter Fifteen

“... L’amore che muove l’universo e l’altre stelle...”

“... The love that moves the Universe and the other stars...”, the Captain announced through their headphones as the students released their seatbelts and began floating.

“Wow!” Yvonne exclaimed as she drifted into a somersault, “I can’t believe this feeling!”

“... So this is weightlessness!” Sebastian said in excitement, “I wouldn’t exchange this for anything”, as he gracefully pushed off the side of the first class cabin and sailed to the other end.

“This is complete freedom”, Kim said as he went through a series of gymnastic movements in unison with Arsami trying different formations. He glanced at the TV screen that was showing a Nature Series and a close-up of worms furrowing through rich soil in time lapse.

All problems and worries were forgotten as the students and the dingo pup experienced the feeling of zero gravity, except for Cathy who made her way towards the Captain’s cabin.

“May I speak to you now?” Cathy asked as she reached the door.

“Of course!” the Captain announced as the hatch slid aside and Cathy floated through into the spacious cockpit with large windows that showed an infinite view of the solar system.

“‘The love that moves the universe’, is a quotation I’ve read somewhere before?” Cathy asked trying to remain calm.

“Ah yes, one of my favourites, the last line of Dante’s ‘Divine Comedy’”, the Captain replied with a smile. “Would you like a cup of coffee?”

“Oh. Yes, thanks. Anyway my name is Cathy.”

“Latte? You should call me Yuri”, the Captain instructed as he pressed some buttons on a consol and took out a sealed cup. He then released it and watched it float over to Cathy who managed to catch it and take a sip.

“Hmm... Delicious. This weightlessness is quite tricky”, Cathy said as she floated upside-down. Yuri, a handsome middle-aged cosmonaut, released his seatbelt and also began floating around the cabin.

Cathy began to feel dizzy then sleepy. Her eyes closed and she went into a deep sleep as she drifted. Yuri smiled and floated over to her.

Inside the first class cabin the others drifted around experimenting and enjoying their newly found freedom. After ten minutes or so Sebastian and Jonathan became concerned.

“Will we join Cathy?” Sebastian asked.

“Yes, I think so. I doubt whether she’ll get the Captain to turn this rocket around”, Jonathan answered.

At that moment the hatch slid aside and Cathy’s red space suit came drifting through. Sebastian made a cursory glance at Jonathan and the others looked alarmed.

Cathy’s naked body then floated through into the first class cabin, relaxed and serenely beautiful. Her long mousy hair drifting in all directions.

“What’s happened?” Sebastian said angrily, “Cathy? Cathy? Wake up!” he gestured urgently as he grabbed her in the air and shook her gently.

“Where am I?” she muttered with slightly slurred speech. Her eyes opened lazily and she had a half smile.

“What have you done?” Sebastian demanded to know.

“Why? Nothing”, Yuri replied in a deep resonating voice through the earphones.

“Yeah okay...” Sebastian replied with a resigned tone as they helped Cathy back into her red space suit and zipped it up. They all returned to their chairs and fastened their seat belts as Cathy woke up completely.

“Do you feel all right?” Jonathan inquired looking into her eyes.

“Yes! Fine, great”, she reassured everyone.

“What happened?” they all asked.

“Don’t know... but whatever was in the coffee, I’d like some more!” Cathy said laughing a bit. And then noticing everyone’s expressions of concern, “What? What’s wrong?”

“Nothing Cathy”, Yvonne answered patting her hand.

A few hours passed and they occupied themselves by reading all the text messages on the mobile phone and listening to the backlog of various recorded messages. Each one had the time and day so it was in itself an interesting history of the adventures they had gone through.

Eventually Valentina floated in and announced that dinner was about to be served and invited them to the glass-dining cabin and informed them that Yuri would like to join them.

“You are all very fortunate”, Yuri said with a smile as he fastened his safety belt that fixed him to his seat at the head of the glass table, “this would be the best restaurant in the universe.”

“We certainly can’t complain about the 360 degree panoramic view!” Jonathan responded as they gazed out the window that surrounded them showing the stars glittering in the solar system.

“Earth and Moon are just ball’s in the distance”, Cathy observed with a glance at Yuri seated next to her, “I guess you get used to it...”

“I have paradigm shifts actually, Cathy”, Yuri explained, “the paradox of time and space is always beguiling, red...?” he asked revealing a bottle of red wine that he squirted into a long stemmed glass with a nozzle on top.

“We’d love some”, Jonathan said. Cathy’s eyes blinked momentarily in hesitation and so Sebastian and Jonathan quickly put forward their glasses. Jonathon tasted it and looked around for any reaction, “.... hmm, Hesperian Epoch, 3 Billion years BC...”

“Da, very good Jonathan”, Yuri replied with a laugh after a moment of surprise, “I see you all will be wonderful company on this trip.”

“Bon appetit!” Valentina announced as she floated in with a pile of eight glass plates filled with steak and chips and crisp salad and handed the guests one each. She sat at the other end of the glass table as they clipped their plates down.

“This steak is perfect”, Kim said, “so what do all the passengers in economy class eat?”

“Mainly fast food that is stored and heated on use”, Valentina explained disdainfully, “since we have a few hundred passengers there. I’m a 5 star chef, so I only cook for first class guests.”

“Valentina informs me your family and everyone think you are all dead and you just watched your funeral on television, da?” Yuri asked with an air of mystery.

“Well that’s not exactly the truth”, Sebastian replied, “but we’re certainly not at home sitting in front of the telly having dinner on a tray”, he continued as he gazed out the huge window at the stars.

“Do you want to watch the news then?” Valentina inquired as she glanced at her watch and pressed a couple of buttons. A large television screen hovered down and flickered on revealing the 7 o’clock news.

“... Controversy continues to follow the disappearance of the four Melbourne students and their aboriginal guide”, the newsreader announced, “after one parent claimed his son rang him during their funeral service at St. Paul’s Cathedral this afternoon and said they were alive.”

“This is the text message we received”, Jonathan’s father said to the camera as he held up the mobile phone and showed the message.

‘WE ARE ALIVE. NOT DEAD’

“And then he rang us and said they were all right, but then our conversation was cut short when the mobile phone went out of network coverage”, Jonathan’s father belatedly explained.

“... And then a scuffle broke out later on when reporters questioned one of the parent’s where a wake was being held”, the newsreader said.

“That’s my house!” Cathy said in surprise as the television showed a crowd of reporters thrusting microphones into the face of Sebastian’s father and mother.

“Is it true that it has been revealed to you that the laptop has been traced to somewhere in the Pacific Ocean going up into the sky?” the reporter asked.

“Yes it has”, Sebastian’s father replied, “and they said the tracking chip in the mobile phone reveals the same thing!”

“So do you think this means your son is going to heaven?” another reporter inquired.

“Don’t be so stupid!” Sebastian’s mother interrupted angrily, “if my son and his friends were dead and were ascending to heaven it would be above Uluru if that is where they perished!” she said and began pushing the reporter and cameraman.

“You’re not really chartered accountants are you?” Yuri said looking around with a scornful expression at each of the students who in turn pursed their lips and peered down looking guilty.

“So how did you get on this flight?” Valentina inquired looking at Cathy and glancing at her mirror lipstick and then looking at Yuri.

“All right then... I stole the mirror lipstick”, Cathy replied avoiding eye contact and shuffling around in her seat uncomfortably.

“Yes, but we had to escape that island!” Sebastian protested quickly in support of Cathy, “or we’d end up as cleaners there for the rest of our lives. You know that...” he concluded.

“Niyet, I don’t”, Yuri responded putting down his knife and fork, “it’s one thing to take a tram trip for a few stops without paying your fare, but this trip is about 200 million kilometres...”

“Student concession?” Jonathan muttered.

“Niyet”, Yuri responded.

“Well, it looks like you’d better turn this thing around and drop us home then”, Cathy said casually strumming her fingers on the glass dining table.

“Niyet can do”, Yuri replied looking deep into her eyes, “we’re stuck with each other until we reach Mars.”

“Then what?” Jonathan chimed in, “will the Martian’s do experiments on us?”

“Niyet, niyet, niyet!” Yuri responded laughing aloud with Valentina snorting along, “it’s nothing like that!”

The frank exchange cleared the tense atmosphere and everyone relaxed and continued eating their meals and sipping on red wine enjoying the breathtaking views.

After dinner Yuri floated back to his cockpit and Valentina showed the students their sleeping quarters.

“I’m in love with Yuri”, Cathy announced in one breath that took everyone off guard.

“Are you sure?” Sebastian asked, “He’s over twice your age...”

“That’s a drop in the ocean compared to the age of the universe...” Cathy blurted back in defence.

“Yes, but he’s a cosmonaut, and he’s from Kazakhstan moreover”, Sebastian tried vainly to reason, “and what will your parents say when you return to earth?”

“And that’s the whole point”, Cathy argued quite soundly, “How the hell do you plan to get back to earth? It’s not like we have a choice of buses!” she snapped angrily.

“Oh all right then”, Sebastian responded in a slightly hurt voice, “it’s your love life...”

No one really knew what to do. The dingo pup floated over and began licking Sebastian on the face but this propelled her into a tailspin and Cathy had to grab the confused pup to stop her rotating out of control.

The Computer's the Thing

“... This must be a dream”, Cathy thought wistfully to herself, “my inner consciousness cannot be so detached from reality...”

Having a shower in the morning was something else again in the first class compartment. A watertight cubicle that was made of glass with one side overlooking the entire universe was available.

Once inside and sealed, jets of warm water spurted from different directions as the face washer and soap drifted around.

“This is more like a cosmic washing machine than a shower”, Sebastian thought to himself as the wash cycle changed to rinse. Then the water stopped and was sucked out and warm air blew around from all angles leaving the passenger to dry and ponder the cleanliness of life in space.

There was an exclusive gymnasium available to the mirror lipstick travellers in first class. This had a surround window overlooking the universe and included bicycles, cross trainers and treadmills for walking and running. The barbells were rarely used.

Kim and Arsami spent most of their time in the Astronomy Compartment. It was fitted out with powerful telescopes and paraphernalia and Kim in particular whiled away the days pottering around on his laptop computer.

After about a week of travel the daily routines were settled and satisfactory amongst the students. Earth was a dot on the cosmic horizon and the red planet was marginally larger.

Everyone became used to the feeling of weightlessness and total freedom and gravity in any form was a distant memory.

Cathy, Yvonne and Arsami were having morning tea one-day midway through their trip when Sebastian and Jonathan decided to float in and visit Kim and see how his work was going. When they entered the astronomy cabin they found Kim in an altered state of excitement.

“Are you all right?” Sebastian asked Kim, “What’s up?”

“Don’t interfere, go away will you?” he demanded. His laptop was open with the lid facing out the large window and a small web camera was set up and pointed at him.

“Isn’t that your dad?” Jonathan inquired as they both noticed Kim’s father, Professor Strong, filling out the screen of the laptop.

“Yes it is. It’s not what you’re thinking!” Kim said with a guilty sense of urgency, “I promise...”

“Kim and I have made video contact!” Professor Strong announced proudly with a stilted image that occasionally faded in and out in clarity.

“Is that really you?” Sebastian asked as they floated around behind Kim and began waving into the web camera.

“Yes boys, tell them Kim...” Professor Strong said with a sense of urgency.

“Okay, but if we lose the picture I’ll try again this time tomorrow”, Kim said to the web cam and then started talking to the others as his father looked on in fascination.

“Please do...” Sebastian replied.

“Basically this laptop lid is fitted with a mini satellite dish and after days of fiddling around getting gibberish and

beeps I managed to receive television from Earth”, Kim explained.

“The same television programmes this rocket gets, you mean?” Jonathan asked.

“Yes. Except I plugged in my little web cam here and sent back an image!” Kim continued in excitement, “and I managed to zero it in on my fathers laptop, which is the same as mine.”

“So couldn’t any other TV station get this image too?” Sebastian inquired suspiciously.

“Well that’s what we’re afraid of when we first tried to make contact”, Kim’s father interrupted, “so we don’t know, yet...”

“And we don’t think it’s a good idea to stay online too long”, Kim said quickly, “In case another TV station, or some government...”

“... Or NASA”, Kim’s father interjected.

“Yes, or some government agency intercepts it”, Kim continued.

“But does it really matter?” Sebastian inquired.

“Hold on”, Kim’s father said looking around. Suddenly he left the screen. The screen went blank. Kim pressed exit and slammed down his laptop lid.

Kim wiped some sweat from his brow and put his head in his hands in despair. They all remained silent for a while. Sebastian looked at the other two.

“Let’s not tell the others”, he suggested, “so we don’t cause any panic or trouble from them, or Yuri for that matter...”

They floated back to the dining cabin and joined the girls having morning tea.

"Why do you have strange expressions on your faces?" Cathy inquired immediately.

"No we don't!" Sebastian replied.

"Yes you do! You're hiding something", Cathy snapped back.

"Not so!" Sebastian protested.

"We're not stupid women earthling's..." Cathy argued, "Arsami has already told us Kim's been trying to make satellite contact with his dad", she mentioned casually.

"... It's just idle gossip", Jonathan said, "... okay, Kim succeeded, but we have a problem..."

"So what are you going to do?" Cathy inquired.

"Nothing", Sebastian replied shrugging his shoulders, "we'll try and make video contact again tomorrow."

"I've found a biting current affairs programme on television that covers everything in depth", Sebastian said to Yuri and Valentina after dinner that evening as everyone looked at the TV.

The programme, entitled 'Abduction or Seduction', gave a brief history of each student. It then concentrated on the mobile phone and the laptop computer and how these machines had been tracked to inside Uluru and then a week later traced going into the upper atmosphere.

It listed the different theories, which everyone already knew all about, but then stepped up a level.

"... However, this programme has received information through an intermediary", the reporter revealed, "that suggests Professor Strong has made video contact with his son Kim via the sophisticated laptop computer Kim has with him..."

“Absolute nonsense”, a spokesman said for the government and rejected this latest theory outright but conceded that Professor Strong was one of the country’s, “...foremost advisors on computer technology and advancement”.

“So that’s what you’ve been up to in the astronomy cabin is it?” Yuri asked looking at Kim, “It must be some laptop you have!” he said with a smile.

“Why do you say that, Yuri?” Kim inquired curiously.

“Well we’ve been travelling between Mars and Earth for thousands of years”, Yuri explained calmly, “and we’ve done so undetected!” The students looked at each other in silence.

“Do you mean this rocket is from Mars?” Sebastian asked incredulously causing Yuri and Valentina to laugh loudly.

“Da! Of course!” Yuri replied still laughing, “Do you think this is some enterprise from Earth?”

“Are you a MARTIAN?” Cathy asked as the dingo pup’s ears pricked up and she growled.

“Niyet!” Yuri replied laughing, “Valentina! Pour me a vodka, and one for our guests!”

Valentina could hardly contain herself snorting with laughter as she opened a panel and squirted a number of vodka’s and began handing them around to the mystified students.

“I was born and bred in Kazakhstan and graduated as a cosmonaut at the TsNIMASH Space Research Centre”, Yuri explained in his smooth manner, “and I did various space walks for the hammer and sickle brigade...”

“Ruskies’ Yuri, use plain English!” Valentina interjected throwing back a vodka in one gulp.

“... And I met my fellow astronaut Valentina here and we married”, Yuri explained.

“We drifted apart years ago...” Valentina quickly reassured everyone, “but we still have a working relationship...”

“Then on one mission our craft appeared to just blow up, ‘KA-BOOM!’”, Yuri explained in his unflappable manner, “But in fact we were head hunted by the Mars people... their money and conditions were a lot better you know.”

“So we’ve been doing the Mars-Earth leg ever since... we just love it”, Valentina concluded with a warm smile.

“Hmmm...” Sebastian responded looking warily concerned, “so why hasn’t NASA or some other space agency detected this rocket on their radar?” he asked.

“Niyet! Impossible!” Yuri replied firmly, “Mars has an advanced civilisation. These craft have all sorts of radar shields and detection blocks.”

“For example, when we arrive at Earth we do so by night and, if anything, we just resemble a meteorite”, Valentina said.

“Well then why has my laptop worked?” Kim inquired with one eyebrow raised.

“Da! That’s a very good question!” Yuri concluded gulping down his vodka and spinning the empty glass across to Valentina for a refill, “it’s a mystery... I’m just the bus driver here!”

“I’m homesick”, Yvonne muttered as she gazed out the window at the crystal clear universe, “I’m sorry...”

“Why?” Yuri asked as he was clearly taken aback.

“I’m descended from the Pitjantjatjara and Yankunytjatjara people, the Anangu tribe...” Yvonne pondered aloud, “we

are desert people and we respect the stars and the universe. I was born in a shelter at the base of Uluru-Kata, THAT ROCK...

... We had such fun dancing around the fire at night. We used to lie down and watch the stars above us. The ancestor spirits were with us all the time with their myths and legends..."

"Yvonne? You're crying..." Cathy whispered as she floated across and put her arm around her. The others all looked momentarily distracted.

'... Oh. She's done it again', Sebastian thought to himself, 'she said she's homesick! Yvonne's so beautiful...'

"Well that's brought us down to earth!" Jonathan said breaking a strange spell in the cabin.

Deimos and Phobos

Fear (Deimos) and terror (Phobos) was what everyone felt as they waited 24 hours to try and make video contact again. The Astronomy Cabin was crowded as they all floated around watching Kim fiddling with his laptop.

“So much pressure!” Kim said with sweat drifting from his forehead as he tapped away on his keyboard. The lid was open and the satellite dish pointed at Earth and the screen changed colour and flickered around until suddenly his father appeared.

“Yes! It worked!” Professor Strong said in a delighted tone.

“Okay then”, Kim said quickly but nervously, “We’re all fine and we land on Mars in a week and...”

“And do what you’re told!” Kim’s mother suddenly shouted as her face filled the screen before it went blank again.

“So. Is that it? The search for intelligent life...” Yuri said with a laugh. Everyone floated in silence for a moment.

“Oh well, I guess you should follow orders Kim”, Sebastian said.

“What now Kim?” Arsami inquired after the students were alone again.

“I’ll keep trying to make contact”, Kim replied. “When my mother demanded I ‘do what you’re told’, it was a code, a game we played when I grew up, it means I should do the opposite.”

“Possibly it’s just wild luck that’s put us here”, Jonathan suggested as they continued to theorise the reason they all

began to feel more special. As if they had some otherworldly extraordinary calling. Or they had been merely singled out by a greater power or force to fulfil a specified mission.

“... Or bad luck”, Yvonne said.

Nonetheless, as the red planet drew closer and their arrival date nearer a noticeable excitement and trepidation began to manifest itself. Yuri was a veritable oasis of information and seemed to answer every single question with interest and honesty.

“What are those two small planets orbiting Mars?” Kim asked Yuri as they viewed the various monitors in the cockpit.

“One is called Deimos and the smaller one is Phobos”, Yuri explained in his usual straightforward manner. “They are artificial planets which the people at Mars put into orbit in 1878 when astronomers from Earth were becoming sticky beaks...”

“What do they do?” Sebastian inquired.

“Not much. Mainly security... they’re like battleships really”, Yuri replied, “They circle around the equator of Mars.”

“But when I study the surface of Mars through this telescope it just seems like a red desert with some rocks and canals”, Kim observed.

“That’s the roof you’re looking at because not only does it hide entire cities, but it acts as insulation”, Yuri continued, “Mars has gone through global warming like Earth but on an enormous scale... it used to have a pleasant balmy atmosphere, the Noachian era.”

“So what are the people like on Mars?” Cathy finally asked Yuri.

“Basically just like you and me”, he answered, shrugging his shoulders.

The curious students canvassed every topic under the sun and on the final night before arriving at the Red Planet a special dinner was prepared by Valentina to celebrate their journey and their friendship.

“Since you claim these people on Mars are an advanced civilisation”, Sebastian asked Yuri as they proposed a toast, “can they travel through time?”

“Da! Certainly!” Yuri responded enthusiastically as the glasses clinked together, “in fact I have travelled in time on a few occasions...”

“What year did you go to?” Arsami inquired.

“This year. That’s all I know”, he answered coolly.

“What do you mean by that?” Sebastian asked.

“Well I can only speak of my experience and others I’ve compared notes with”, Yuri explained, “you see, once you time travel your mind thinks you are at your own time.”

“How do you do it?” Kim inquired.

“Like what has been commonly theorised already, through a worm hole in space. You go in at one time and come out at another!” he replied, “Time tunnels are parallel.”

“So has this journey from Earth to Mars been in a time tunnel?” Jonathan inquired.

“Niyet. Because you made video contact with Kim’s father, so I don’t think we have”, Yuri said, “when we arrive on Mars tomorrow, it will be much the same as when I left it... I hope...”

“This should make you less homesick”, Sebastian said to Yvonne as they had breakfast and gazed out to see the surface of Mars filling the entire window, “since it looks like the red centre.”

It was mainly red with some orange patches here and there. Everyone had the same strange view of the ‘angry planet’, which the Romans named after their terrible god of war.

After breakfast they all adjourned to the cockpit at the invitation of Yuri and sat obediently in a row of seats behind the pilot.

“There might be a small amount of turbulence since we’re going through some giant sandstorms”, Yuri warned.

Indeed these strong, dry blasts howled angrily around them, as the surface loomed closer.

“Hold on! We’re going to crash!” Jonathan said in alarm. The sandstorm swirled and the red ground rushed towards the window.

“Relax!” Yuri said calmly as the bright redness passed over the window and the rocket seemingly entered the surface of Mars coming out below like an aeroplane passing through cloud.

The dingo pup had her paws over her eyes and she then peeked through two quivering claws to see an enormous valley with a city.

“Done!” Yuri announced proudly, “we’ve entered the ceiling and right up their in the distance you can see the airport!”

“It’s just like what you said”, Cathy exclaimed in admiration, “a roof over an entire sprawling city!”

“Da! Incredible. The civilisation’s here took hold and evolved in these enormous canals over millions of years”,

Yuri explained gesturing widely across the expansive cockpit window, “and when global warming began they simply roofed over the canals.”

“There are mountains and trees and this sun looks beautiful”, Cathy exclaimed in astonishment as she grabbed her camera and snapped a photo of the panoramic spectacle with Yuri’s smiling face in the middle.

“Well with the reddish ceiling it filters out a lot of the heat and also gives a permanent sunset effect during daylight hours”, Yuri explained proudly, “and my favourite colour is red!”

“I’m beginning to feel a gravitational pull”, Jonathan observed.

“Well it’s about half that of Earth”, Yuri responded.

“I guess after we land we won’t see you again?” Sebastian asked Yuri and Valentina.

“Niyet, I’m afraid. I have a de-briefing on this flight then I prepare for my next one”, Yuri replied, “I’m sorry.”

As the airport became clearer and closer they could make out rockets and spaceships scattered about with some flying saucers hovering around. The landing wheels on their rocket opened down and they landed and began taxiing along the runway.

“I didn’t even notice the actual landing”, Jonathan said in surprise, “I guess you have advanced landing gear.”

The rocket finally came to a standstill. They all exchanged farewells and a door opened revealing a luminous red stretch limousine with a middle-aged gentleman standing there in a conservative dark suit and tie. The students descended a short escalator onto the tarmac.

“Welcome. I’m Cecil Snodgrass, your chauffeur and butler”, he said with a clear London accent in a friendly manner.

“That’s a funny name for a Martian”, Jonathan replied.

Cecil at first looked surprised and then hurt. There was a momentary pause. His bottom lip began to quiver and the corners of his mouth arced down as tears started to well up in his eyes.

“Jonathan! What have you done?” Cathy said angrily.

“I’m terribly sorry Cecil, I didn’t mean any offence”, Jonathan replied quickly realising his apparent insult.

“We’re NOT Martians, Sir”, Cecil replied trying hard to regain his composure, “we are just like you, people!” He whipped out the crisply pressed hanky chief from his top pocket and blew his nose and wiped away some tears.

“Of course you are!” Sebastian interceded apologetically, “we’re all the same really...”

“Yes Sir. But may I suggest we all look the same”, Cecil responded gaining confidence and tucking away his hanky chief, “but maybe we are slightly more advanced...”

“Of course you are!” Cathy said rapidly to back up Sebastian and calm the drama, “we all know that!”

“May we go then?” Cecil enquired standing stiffly as he opened the door of the limousine and everyone clambered in.

“Everything seems the same as it is on Earth”, Sebastian observed, “except for those flying saucers hovering around. Even those other cars look the same...”

The stretch limousine sped down a highway with the six students seated opposite each other peering out the tinted windows.

“Excuse me, Cecil”, Cathy said tapping on the glass partition that separated them from the chauffeur, “I noticed some Daleks remonstrating with people over there. Are they dangerous?”

“Goodness gracious no, Madam”, Cecil replied glancing in the rear view mirror and chuckling, “they’re giving parking fines. We have robots here for that sort of trivial work and the local senate decided to adopt that design from the Dr. Who TV series... terribly popular here.”

A Dalek was in the process of placing a parking ticket on the windscreen of a car parked illegally and other cars were being hastily moved as more Daleks approached shrieking, ‘Exterminate! Annihilate! Destroy!’

“One of the benefits of being advanced and observing Earth so closely”, Cecil explained, “is that we can adopt any ideas we like.”

The stretch limousine turned off the freeway and sped along tree lined suburban streets with large houses. Normal every day people went about their daily lives and other than the permanent red sunset effect over the entire city everything seemed the same as on Earth.

“It’s hard to actually believe we’re on Mars”, Sebastian concluded. As they drove along, the large houses changed to opulent mansions and the estates they passed became wealthier.

Finally they reached a huge stately mansion tucked away among hills and tall wrought iron gates were swung open as they approached. The limousine cruised up a long

winding drive through spectacular gardens and pulled up outside an imposing front door.

Chapter Eighteen

‘Gemuetlichkeit’¹

“This is your house where you will live”, Cecil announced as he opened the limousine door. They all stepped out looking around in awe. “You have everything you need at your disposal including 15 servants, 3 chefs, 12 gardeners and don’t forget I’m your butler.”

The students strolled through the front door into the atrium and then they climbed the wide staircase to the second floor as Cecil showed them around.

“It all seems a bit too good to be true”, Sebastian said as he scratched his head and looked out a window at the expansive garden below.

“I’ve seen two swimming pools, a tennis court and even a maze”, Jonathan said as they strolled past a drawing room and paused to admire the billiards table in the games room.

“Lunch will be served shortly”, Cecil announced, “and may I suggest you freshen up?”

Before long everyone was seated around the long dining table in the banquet room with servants standing nearby at the ready.

“Ah good. Our dinner guest has arrived on time”, Cecil said looking out the window as a Volkswagen convertible came speeding up the drive and screeched to a halt. A shaggy-haired gentleman wearing a cardigan stepped out and shuffled towards the mansion.

¹ friendly joviality

“May I introduce Albert Einstein?” Cecil inquired as everyone stood up in surprise and Einstein appeared at the door with a smile and a nod.

“To what do we deserve this honour?” Sebastian inquired in his politest manner.

“DNA”, Einstein replied quickly, “Ven I died in 1955 my ashes were scattered except for my brain! My pathologist sold part of it to Mars agents and zey bought it back here and reconstructed me in entirety!” Einstein recalled.

“Oh. Can they do that?” Jonathan asked.

“Ya, of course. Zis is a very advanced civilisation. Zat suburb over zthere”, Einstein explained gesturing out the window, “has zousands of reconstructed humans from earth; Dadaists, Cubists, Freudians, dictators, vock stars, the vorks!”

“Dictators?” Jonathan replied in shock.

“Ya! Vun of zee most popular TV programmes here is Big Brother vith a house containing Mao, Hitler, Stalin, Pol Pot, those ilk”, Einstein explained excitedly.

“Who was voted out first?” Jonathan inquired.

“Voting? Zthere is no voting! It’s a dictatorship! Zat’s the whole point!” Einstein responded scratching his head, “it’s the longest vunning programme on TV here. Zey stole the idea from Earth.”

“May I suggest we sit down for lunch? We have your favourite dish, Albert!” Cecil announced as everyone sat down with Einstein at the head of the table, “Rheinischer Sauerbraten!”

“Ya good. Beef voast stewed vith vine! Zankyou Snodgrass!” Einstein said as waiters busied themselves

pouring drinks and placing napkins on everyone's laps and one around the dingo pup as she chewed on a fossil.

"... What on Mars will we talk about...?" Sebastian wondered to himself, "since here is the man who said, 'Only two things are infinite, the universe and human stupidity, and I'm not about the former'..."

"So, what's life on Mars like here?" Jonathan asked after a moment of silence as the waiters passed around Badener Schneckensuepple, a snail chowder flowered with herbs.

"Ya. Good question", Einstein said, "Vell vrecently NASA landed that six veeled rover on the Meridian Planum to collect samples and the Mars people asked me vot zey should do about it", Einstein explained as he wiped chowder from his bushy moustache.

"So I said, 'look, give zem somezing to analyse!' So zey scattered a whole lot of dark red powder around zee machine and it consequently scooped it up, analysed it, and sent the results back to Earth."

"What did they find?" Cathy asked politely.

"Coca Cola powder!" Einstein replied laughing away heartily, "you zee, vee play zese little jokes vith NASA. Harmless vun vearly!"

Hauptsperser, the main course, was served including Spannferkel, spit roasted baby pig, Bulletten, meatballs, and Soeier, pickled eggs as the students described their journey to Einstein.

"So all those chartered accountants we came across below the island they called Hawaii are from Mars?" Jonathan asked in disbelief.

“Ya. Sometimes vun pays most for zee zings vun gets for nothing”, Einstein replied. “And zis computer you zay Kim has... can I zee it?”

“Yes of course”, Kim replied eagerly, “I will be happy to show it to you after this lunch.”

“Ya good! Oh! And Schwarzwaldler kirschtorte!” Einstein said happily as Cecil served the desert, Black Forest cake, “my favourite vith Bavarian vanilla crème!”

“May I suggest you all adjourn to the nursery for your Bluemchenkaffee?” Cecil asked.

“Ah! Small flower coffee is zee best coffee Snodgrass”, Einstein replied as he stood up and brushed the Black Forest Cake crumbs off his red cardigan, “zat vas a delicious lunch, sank you.”

Everyone strolled out to the large nursery that had a table and chairs in the centre on a patio and was surrounded by exotic plants and statues and the whole room was encased in glass. The waiters poured out the coffee and handed around mints while the students lounged comfortably in their green surroundings.

“Do you miss life on Earth, Albert?” Sebastian inquired as he sipped on his coffee.

“Ya and nine. You zee, life is very good here, and after all is said and done, I’ve all veady had vun life from 1879 to 1955, so zis new life is veady icing on zee cake”, Einstein explained, “but, ya, I guess if sthere is an after-life, zis is it...”

“But it’s not exactly heaven, is it”, Jonathan replied, “I mean you’ve proved by being here that you’re not in heaven and therefore there might not be a God”, he continued

biting on an after dinner mint. Einstein stroked his chin and dropped a lump of sugar in his coffee and stirred it.

“Hmmm... vot veally interests me is vether God had any choice in the creation of the world”, he replied.

“So do you think the people from here created the world millions of years ago?” Sebastian suggested.

“Nine! Zey are advanced, but not zat advanced. I sink Mars is just another cog in the cosmos”, he responded.

“Well I miss life on Earth”, Yvonne said taking the think tank by surprise. They all looked at her and thought for a while.

“... God she’s beautiful, Sebastian pondered quietly to himself, maybe it’s her graceful features, or just the way she keeps bringing us back to basics...”

“Vot do you miss most?” Albert asked as he too secretly admired Yvonne’s stunning indigenous features.

“My family. I miss my family right now. What do you think?” Yvonne inquired.

“You mean my theory of relatives?” Einstein asked as he placed his cup on the saucer and studied the coffee granules.

“Well yes”, she answered curiously.

“Zat is an interesting question”, Albert replied with a nod of approval, “Ven I vas on Earth I only zaw zem at Christmas and zey gave me presents. Vun Christmas I got 17 pocket calculators. Vot an inzult.”

At that moment Kim entered the nursery holding his laptop computer and placed it on the table and the others cleared the saucers away.

“Well here it is”, Kim announced proudly as he opened the lid and switched it on.

“Vot’s so special about it?” Einstein inquired.

“Firstly this lid acts as a solar and satellite dish”, Kim explained, “but most importantly I can make video contact with earth and it can’t be blocked by the advanced civilisation here on Mars.”

“Zat’s amazing!” Einstein exclaimed, “zis means our cover vill be blown here! Zis vill have major ramifications!”

“Who for?” Jonathan wondered aloud.

“Earth! Mars! Zee Universe! Time! Matter! Energy! Everyzing! Holy cow!” Einstein said throwing up his arms in excitement.

“Will I try and make contact? Yes or no?” Kim asked tersely looking at the others.

“Ya! Of course! Zthere shouldn’t be any zecrets in our universe!”

“Well I don’t know Kim. You know what your father said”, Cathy mentioned calmly.

“In that case I will then”, Kim said tapping on the connect key.

The screen showed the satellite was searching and it began to flicker with different colours and patterns making bips, beeps, babble and twaddle sounds as everyone looked on with intense interest.

“Vot’s vis all zis babble and twaddle noise?” Einstein inquired.

“Well my laptop is trying to find a suitable dish on Earth”, Kim explained, “and it could zero in on any one.”

“There are millions of satellite dishes”, Arsami said, “so it might link up with one in Mongolia, or the Antarctic, or anywhere...”

“Why not your father’s identical laptop again?” Jonathan asked.

“Well we only connected because we searched for each other at the same time...” Kim explained.

Flying Saucers

The newsroom in Melbourne was quiet. Reporters ambled around watering the pot plants and filling in crosswords. The phone rang on the Chief of Staff's vacant desk and the cleaner polishing the floor nearby answered it.

"Hullo? News here, how may I assist you?" she said.

"It's Studio 3 here, we're getting some interference with our satellite cross to Canberra for an interview. We've got some guy who claims to be Einstein on the line."

"Well record it and we might be able to use it on 'Silliest Home Videos' or something. Thanks", the cleaner replied slamming down the phone.

In Studio 3 they alerted telecine to keep recording and since the compere had gone to the canteen the floor manager sat down in the anchor's chair and conducted the interview.

"We're talking to Albert Einstein", the floor manager said to the camera then swivelled around to the large screen, "... So Einstein, have you broken any chalk on your blackboard recently?"

"Have I vot? Oh! Chalk! Ya, all zee time", Einstein said with a pause of momentary confusion, "but I have somezing of vital importance to zay."

"What, that you've discovered the mathematical formula for stronger chalk?"

"Vot?"

"Are you saying this could revolutionise teaching?" the floor manager asked laughing away with the floor crew.

“Nine! Vill you shut up and listen!” Einstein replied angrily. “Vot vill I do about zis idiot, Sebastian?”

Sebastian and Jonathan stood up and walked behind Einstein and they all peered into the web camera lens.

“Hullo? We’re telecasting from Mars here, is there someone there we can speak to?” Sebastian asked.

“Aren’t they two of the missing students from Uluru?” The make-up lady said to the cameraman looking more closely at the TV monitor as it faded in and out a bit.

A buzz began to erupt around the studio. The compere ran into the studio fumbling with his earpiece as the bewildered floor manager abruptly vacated the chair from the compere’s desk.

“Powder! Powder me!” the compere yelled angrily to the make-up artist as she puffed a brush over his forehead.

“We are all alive and well!” Cathy said to the web camera as they put their arms around each other behind Albert.

“Ya! And I’m Albert Einstein speaking to you live from Mars”, he said in a delighted tone.

The compere tried to ask a question but the tangled cord from the earpiece tightened around his neck. Suddenly the screen went blank.

“We’ve lost contact”, Sebastian said as Kim tapped a few more keys but the screen was still blank.

“Vell vee can try again later...” Albert suggested, “but zat may be too late”, he continued as they all noticed a flying saucer hovering over the mansion.

“Do you think they have traced the source of our video contact?” Kim asked as Albert nodded and pointed to the laptop.

After a while the flying saucer hovered down and landed on the nearby croquet field. A door opened up then folded down and a short escalator began running as a man in a suit descended and strolled over to the nursery.

“They made contact with Earth, Sir”, Cecil said to the man.

“Yes, I know”, he replied. His demeanour showed no animosity towards them or what they had just achieved. “My name is Walter. I’m from the Senate, which is the governing body here”, he explained calmly. “I’m afraid we don’t want Earth finding out about us...”

“Why not Walter?” Einstein inquired, “we could be celestial neighbours living in harmony.”

“Harmony?” Walter replied in surprise.

“Are you going to do experiments on us?” Jonathan chimed in. Snodgrass became upset and tears welled up in his eyes.

“Look! We’re not like that...” Cecil replied with a quivering voice.

“So we’re sending you back to Earth”, Walter announced, “for work experience.”

“Work experience?” Sebastian exclaimed in surprise, “why do we need...”

“Shut up Sebastian!” Cathy said angrily, “don’t argue...”

“Now if you could gather your belongings we leave shortly and we keep this computer...” Walter said firmly as Kim started to pick up his laptop but Walter put his hand on it.

“Zat is good! I need zee latest laptop!” Albert said eagerly.

“Wrong again”, Walter replied without hesitation, “you’re going with them, Einstein.”

Within minutes they had collected their fawn briefcases and satchels and were strolling towards the flying saucer with Albert scratching his shaggy hair as he shuffled along and the dingo pup scampering around beside them.

“After you...” Walter said as they all stepped onto the short escalator that took them up into the flying saucer. The door closed behind them and the flying saucer made a loud humming noise and hovered up into the sky then whooshed off sideways.

The students, dingo pup and Einstein sat in silence on comfortable chairs inside the craft. The only other person on board was Walter who stood in the middle operating a control panel.

“I’m taking you to the airport”, Walter informed them, “and then you take the rocket back to Earth.”

“Oh well, First Class rocket travel was great...” Jonathan reasoned.

“You should put this science fiction nonsense out of your head”, Walter replied.

The flying saucer hovered to a standstill and descended at the airport. The door opened.

“Out...” Walter ordered.

A large bus-like vehicle stood in front of them with no windows. Some men in suits gestured for them to enter. When they stepped inside they found it was packed with other people. They were bundled into darkness and the door slammed shut.

“Vot is going on here?” Albert asked.

“We don’t know”, replied an unfamiliar voice in the dark.

Soon they found themselves in a large compartment with about a hundred people. There were no seats and only a couple of small windows.

“The lipstick!” Arsami whispered to Cathy, “have you got the mirror lipstick?”

“Oh! Yes! Hold the pup”, Cathy whispered as she handed Sebastian the pup and searched through her satchel, “Ah! Got it”, she said as she quickly applied it to her lips and then handed it onto Arsami and Yvonne, “... hurry.”

Finally they finished and pushed their way through the crowded compartment to a man guarding the door.

“Here! Look!” Cathy said forcefully as she and the others pushed their lips out at the guard.

“... At what?” the guard inquired.

“Our lipstick! It’s mirror!” Cathy explained impatiently.

“So I can see myself in your lips”, the guard replied.

“So we should be in First Class!” Cathy answered angrily.

“I don’t see the connection. Surely if you want to be in First Class you should have a First Class ticket? No wonder you’re being sent to Earth”, he replied.

“Oh...” Cathy said feeling foolish, “I guess so...” They retreated sheepishly into the crowded compartment. Then the door closed.

The engines began firing up and suddenly there was an enormous surge that threw all the passengers up one end of the compartment. None of them had safety belts or even seats for that matter.

There was groaning and crying as the passengers untangled themselves once the rocket was airborne. The rocket

surged through the hole in the ceiling that covered the civilisation of Mars and into outer space.

Gradually the pull of gravity diminished and the hundred odd passengers started floating around from the weightlessness. This made the conditions worse as people began bumping into each other.

The students and Einstein floated around in a huddle holding onto each other. This went on for days and everyone could only despair about it all.

Three times a day a hatch would open and packets of fast food would come drifting through with plastic bottles of water. The students estimated this would go on for three weeks since this was the length of their trip from Earth to Mars.

“We are about to enter a worm hole so there will be some turbulence”, came an announcement over the speaker.

“That’s Yuri’s voice!” Cathy exclaimed with surprise.

“A worm hole?” Albert uttered in amazement, “we must be going to travel in time!”

“Yuri is in the cockpit!” Cathy continued in excitement, “I’ll tell him we’re in here!” She floated towards the food hatch and began knocking on it.

But there was no answer.

Suddenly there was a loud roar and the rocket began to vibrate violently. Kim and Arsami were close to a porthole and peered out at the universe.

“The stars are all long streaks!” Kim described to the others as everyone shook, “We must be going faster than light! Wow! Look at the colours!”

“Hold on to each other tighter!” Sebastian ordered, “this is terrible, my vision is blurring!”

The noise became louder and the vibrating worse. All the passengers started to lose consciousness and soon the compartment was full of bodies floating around limply and aimlessly.

Chapter Twenty

Earth

“It’s a full Moon!” Jonathan said as he looked out the porthole at the night moon that looked immense. Everywhere in the compartment the passengers began to regain consciousness.

“I’ve had zee time of my life!” Einstein exclaimed as he floated around in excitement.

But it wasn’t the case for everyone. Some passengers had died in the wormhole and the survivors pushed their bodies through the food hatch.

It was a strange experience physically but the students felt healthy enough, although mentally apprehensive. The thought of work experience on Earth was a worry.

“What time in history do you think we’ve travelled to?” Sebastian asked Albert.

“History?” Einstein replied, “Vee might have gone to zee future! Who knows?” he asked as he ran his fingers through his shaggy hair.

After a couple of hours the Moon was smaller and Earth loomed large. Outside the portholes there was fire and the rocket began to vibrate again.

“We must be entering the earths atmosphere”, Jonathan suggested as he peered out the window.

‘Bip, bip... bip, bip...’ came the sound from the mobile phone.

“The mobile phone”, Jonathan remembered as he fumbled urgently through his fawn briefcase. He found it and tapped the text message button.

‘WE SAW YOU ON TV’

“We must have network coverage for a moment!” Jonathon said as he showed the message to the others.

“Phone them!” Sebastian ordered. Jonathan tapped away again.

“It’s ringing! Hullo?” Jonathan said loudly.

“Where are you now?” came an unfamiliar voice. “Are you alright?”

Suddenly there was a crash as the rocket hit the water and everyone was thrown around the compartment finishing in a heap of passengers at one end and this was made worse as they regained gravity.

“We lost network coverage again”, Jonathan lamented.

“Oh well, at least we made brief contact”, Sebastian replied.

“But how can this be if we’ve travelled in time?” Kim inquired looking at Albert.

“Zat is a good question!” Einstein replied. “Maybe the mobile phone doesn’t know zis!”

Finally the rocket came to a standstill. They were all herded down a long dimly lit corridor and found themselves at a railway station.

It was plain and drab and was nothing like the gleaming mirror station. But then again, after their experience of the journey back to Earth, nothing was the same anymore.

A train stood there with a number of carriages and the hundred odd people were told to get on board. The carriages were uncomfortable and crowded as the train pulled out of the station and headed into a tunnel. The only redeeming feature was that the carriages had seats.

“It’s like convict transportation, really”, Sebastian suggested.

“Vorse! It could be zee final solution!” Einstein lamented.

“Really?” Cathy responded, “They wouldn’t go to this much trouble to kill us... would they?”

After a couple of days the train began to slow down and arrived at an underground station made from stone with some polished granite.

All the passengers were ordered off the train and congregated on the station platform where they were handed clothes to change into which were made of loincloth like a short kilt and sandals with cord.

“Jonathon!” Sebastian whispered, “Try and keep the mobile phone...”

Jonathan managed to smuggle the phone under his belt and Cathy secured the dingo pup under her loincloth dress. Then all their discarded clothes were collected by the guards and placed into sacks on the train. Finally a guard addressed the passengers.

“We have arrived at your destination for work experience”, he said in a gruff bossy voice. “You will now be fed and then you have a one day walk ahead of you before you start work.”

Some more guards emerged from a door with plates of food, which they placed on a long wooden table like a buffet. This consisted of bread made from grain called Emmer-wheat, and salad with onions, garlic, lettuce and cucumbers. Flasks of beer made from barley grain were also plonked on the table and everyone began eating.

“I hope you enjoy this cuisine”, the guard joked, “because you’ll be eating it for the next 20 years.”

“Hmmm... it seems pretty basic”, Sebastian said to Jonathan under his breath as Albert studied the writing on the wall and attempted to decipher it correctly.

“Unless I’m mistaken”, Einstein announced to the students, “those hieroglyphics on the stone wall there would seem to be ancient Egyptian.”

“Really?” Cathy said in surprise, “that would fit in with these loincloths we’ve been forced to wear...”

“Vell there is more”, Albert continued, “I sink those hieroglyphic ideograms and pictograms are Egyptian for ‘Cairo Underground Vailway Station!’”

The students looked at each other in silence. They didn’t need Einstein to spell out the next step of their incredible journey but soon enough the next step began when the guards ordered them to start marching.

Reluctantly all 100 passengers entered a long stone corridor that was dank and only lit by sporadic electric lights on the roof of the tunnel. It was hot and stuffy and the hiking was relentless and mostly on an uphill gradient.

Occasionally they came across a series of stone steps as the corridor meandered its way. It was particularly hard on the passengers from Mars because they had grown up with a lighter pull of gravity so walking on earth made them feel like they were obese.

After about six hours of marching they reached a heavy metal door. One guard tapped in some numbers on a small control panel and the door slowly opened with a hum.

Everyone was ushered through and new guards dressed in long white robes carrying flaming torches for lighting met

them. These guards couldn't speak English but yelled and swore at them in Egyptian.

The marching continued and the contingent became more spread out as some tired. This wasn't the case for the five students who were young and fit and even the dingo pup scampered along happily.

"It's mind over matter"; Albert joked at one stage as he explained his physical prowess.

After a while the walls of the tunnel began to change in appearance. They became corridors lined with Aswan pink granite and the floor was more polished.

"Wow!" Arsami exclaimed as they stopped momentarily to admire an unfinished painting on the wall, "this looks like a Pharaoh." Kim touched it and looked at his finger.

"It's still wet. It must be a work in progress", he suggested.

"Zee hieroglyphics there below it suggest its King Khufu!" Albert explained in excitement.

"Who's he?" Jonathan inquired but the conversation was cut short.

'Bip, bip... bip, bip... bip, bip...' came the familiar sound and one of the guards looked around furiously and screamed something.

"Turn it off Jonathan!" Sebastian whispered urgently as he began to whistle to cover the noise. Jonathan fumbled quickly under the loincloth and felt for the right buttons as one of the guards pushed him to keep walking.

A few yards on Jonathan withdrew the mobile phone and glanced at the text message.

'R U IN CAIRO ?'

“Hey Sebastian!” Jonathan whispered, “The text message asked if we’re in Cairo!”

“The tracking chip must still be working somehow!” Sebastian replied in hushed excitement. Further on Jonathan managed to type in a text message, ‘YES’ and pressed send.

‘NO NETWORK COVERAGE’

“It won’t go through”, Jonathan whispered to Sebastian.

The corridor suddenly opened into a large unfinished tomb with craftsmen working on various parts of it. There were painters and stonemasons going about their daily work and they paid no attention to the crowd of people filing through.

“Book of zee Dead”, Albert whispered solemnly to the others, “is zee term used to describe a text used in funerals and vill be placed in zis tomb!” Einstein explained.

“What?” Yvonne inquired breaking a long silence.

“I believe vee are inside zee construction site of zee tomb for King Khufu!” Albert announced quietly before the guard ordered them to keep walking.

“What exactly are you getting at?” Yvonne asked Albert, “you can tell me, I’m an experienced guide now...”

“Vee are inside a pyramid!” Einstein said loudly as his words echoed around the chamber that would one day contain a dead King Khufu.

“Oh! I see...” Yvonne said as she pondered the significance of it all, but there wasn’t time for idle astonishment since a guard pushed them to keep walking.

After about an hour of weaving around what appeared to be a maze they suddenly found light at the end of the tunnel and finally they walked out into direct sunshine.

“It’s zee Giza Plateau!” Einstein announced to the others, “and zat must be Cairo over sthere”, he said pointing to a large settlement of mud brick houses with thatched roofs.

“Will you look at this?” Jonathan exclaimed as he turned around, “we’ve come out of a half finished pyramid!”

“Ya! I sort so! Zis is Cheops!” Albert explained, “Zee Great Pyramid of Khufu under construction. It’s amazing!”

“So we’ve travelled to what time?” Sebastian inquired as the rest of the passengers began emerging from the pyramid bedraggled and tired.

“It vas completed avound 2550 BC”, Albert suggested, “so I guess it’s now 2570 BC... you zee, zese pyramids take nearly 50 years to build, and zis vun is zee biggest!”

“So you think there’s another 20 years work needed on this baby?” Jonathan asked.

“Ya! And vot’s vorse, I zink zis is our vork experience!” Albert said as some guards started pushing them towards a huge ramp that had dozens of stone blocks being pulled on sledges by slaves.

It was definitely a construction site in progress and even though it was late afternoon and a perfect red sunset was forming over the River Nile one shift was finishing and another one was about to begin.

“You lot get over here and push this block of stone”, a slave yelled at them, “we’re off to dinner then bed...”

“Oh, so you can speak English?” Sebastian asked as he began pushing a two tonne block with the others.

“Yes! Of course! Most of the slaves here speak English!” he replied as he sauntered off. Sebastian wanted to keep talking but a guard came over holding a whip.

Chapter Twenty-One

Egypt

Blood, sweat and tears was the only experience they seemed to gain from working on the Great Pyramid of Khufu.

The sun finally set and it was marginally cooler but their Za or work gang had only managed to move the two tonne block of stone about 10 inches up the quite steep ramp.

“I’ve done some calculations in my head”, Albert said breathlessly, “and I estimate it will take 2,300,000 blocks to build this pyramid...”

“King Khufu must have an enormous ego”, Sebastian replied, “Why would a Pharaoh want such a monumental tomb?”

“Well, you see everyman here believes the Pharaoh maintains order in the universe”, Albert explained.

“And so they bring in slaves from other planets...?” Jonathan inquired.

“Well maybe the local Egyptians are too lazy”, Albert concluded.

“Okay, STOP! Stop work!” a guard yelled, “you will be shown to your quarters now. Go away”, he ordered waving his arms as another shift took over. A young Egyptian woman approached them with a warm smile.

“My name is Lucinda, can you come with me?” she asked as they all wandered down the long ramp exhausted and bruised.

After a fifteen-minute walk they reached a number of mud brick houses near the base of the pyramid that housed the slaves.

“The shock of the first shift is the worst”, Lucinda explained as she showed them a house with mangy straw mattresses and some clay urns of water scattered around.

They drank the clean water and washed the blood and sweat from their exhausted bodies and everyone had severe sunburn and blisters from pulling the ropes.

“Zis is much harder zan vorking out knew theories”, Albert lamented as the dingo pup sat on his lap panting.

“I am a local citizen”, Lucinda explained, “but I speak English because I learnt it from slaves like yourself who have arrived from Mars.”

“Oh! You know we’re from Mars?” Sebastian inquired.

“Yes, of course. This has been going on for as long as I can remember”, Lucinda replied. “It’s the worst kept secret in Egypt. We’re not supposed to talk about it, but I do because I’m fascinated by it.”

“Well we’re not from Mars actually”, Sebastian explained in a matter-of-fact way. “We’re originally from Earth, 21st Century AD, and we travelled to Mars and then came back in a time tunnel...”

There was a long silence as Lucinda absorbed this piece of information.

“Oh! That’s different then!” Lucinda finally replied as her eyes widened with admiration.

“When’s dinner?” Jonathan asked, “we’re famished after all that work experience building the King’s cemetery.”

“Listen”, Lucinda said quietly, “I have lots of friends who work as servants for the King. Why don’t I take you to the Palace and you can eat there?”

“Really? Is it safe?” Cathy asked.

“Yes, just don’t speak until I say so”, Lucinda cautioned as they all stood up and followed her into the warm Cairo night.

They walked along lanes and fields and past camels and carts for half an hour until they reached some small houses located next to a sizeable palace.

Lucinda knocked on a door and spoke to a friend and they went inside the house and changed into long white robes that the King’s servants had to wear on duty.

“You’ll have to brush your shaggy hair”, Lucinda told Albert.

“But I haven’t brushed my hair since 1930!” Einstein protested.

“Security is really slack in Egypt”, Lucinda mentioned as they walked to the main gate of the Palace and strolled in without any problems since the guards assumed they were servants.

Before long they reached the servants quarters that were quite luxurious since being a servant to the King was about the best job you could get. Lucinda introduced them to some of her friends and they sat down around a long table.

It was nearly 11.00 pm and the King’s chefs were preparing Suhur, the mid night meal which consisted of various fish dishes and a freshly netted catch from The Nile had just been delivered.

“Poisson ‘a la Grecque, baked fish, is delicious”, Lucinda revealed with her pleasant Egyptian accent, “and the Tagin samak bi-l-firik, fish casserole with hulled grain, is excellent...”

The best wines in civilisation were poured from gold plated flasks and Fatush, home-style bread salad, was served as

everyone sat around discussing the theories of who exactly thought up the original idea of a pyramid.

“Well, one rumour that’s been doing the rounds for a few centuries”, Lucinda explained, “says that the Martian civilisation actually colonised earth thousands of years ago and they dug all these tunnels everywhere...”

“You mean like the one that ends here at the pyramid?” Cathy asked as she tore apart some Fatush.

“Yes. But there’s one to The Great Wall also”, she continued.

“Really? I know Chinese dynasties go back a long way”, Kim responded with interest.

“Apparently this has been used as an underground trade route between our two dynasties for generations”, Lucinda replied.

“And we’ve heard of other tunnels leading to some place called The Incas and another site called Stone Henge”, a friend of Lucinda’s chimed in as a plate of savoury figs, leeks and dates was passed around.

“Why would an advanced civilisation from Mars want to build all these monuments?” Albert wondered aloud.

“Tourism I guess”, Jonathan answered.

“And evidently all these tunnels lead to some huge underground place where thousands of people gather with papyrus scrolls, and quills and abacuses and do the accounting for these projects”, Lucinda explained in a hushed voice.

“Hawaii...” Sebastian replied glancing at the others.

Suddenly the room was a buzz of forbidden gossip. A man swept in wearing a flowing red gown and began looking at the different women.

“What’s happening?” Cathy whispered to Lucinda.

“Oh no! It’s the King’s advisor, he’s been told to get a virgin for King Khufu!” Lucinda replied trying to keep a low profile.

“Can he do that?” Arsami asked.

“Of course he can, he’s the Pharaoh, the most powerful man on earth!” Lucinda replied.

The man stopped and looked closely at Cathy and began touching her hair. Within seconds he snapped his fingers and another couple of soldiers arrived and grabbed her.

“But I’m not a virgin!” Cathy yelled in protest as she was dragged out of the room.

“I’m so sorry...” Lucinda pleaded apologetically to the others who sat silently in shock, “and there’s nothing we can do”, she lamented.

The dinner continued in a somewhat subdued manner as the students glanced nervously at each other. After about 15 minutes Cathy strolled in again and sat down with a strange expression.

“I was taken into this amazing bedroom chamber and had my white robe ripped off”, she related with a blank face, “and I was thrown onto the Kings enormous bed and he made love to me and then he rolled over and went to sleep...”

“Vot does he look like?” Albert enquired ingenuously.

“He’s young and terribly good looking is my King Khufu...” Cathy replied as she stared wistfully into space.

“Anyway, where were we?” Lucinda asked, “oh yes... So most of the slaves for these monuments are Martian labour.”

“And what happens to us then?” Sebastian asked with a frown.

“Well you’re worked to death and then buried”, Lucinda’s friend replied.

“Do we get buried alongside Cathy’s new boyfriend?” Jonathan wondered.

“Don’t be silly”, Lucinda jealously scolded, “The slaves are buried outside the pyramid in unmarked graves.”

“Hmmm...” Albert said scratching his brushed hair, “zat returns us to zee original problem, how can vee get out of zis vork experience?”

Some Feteer Bel Asaag, pastry with ground lamb, was served along with Egyptian Marinade, whole butter fried chicken, as the students ate and discussed their dilemma with Albert.

“I noticed when we passed those hieroglyphics in the tunnel before the burial chamber that the mobile phone worked”, Sebastian said as he looked at Lucinda. “Can we go back to that place tomorrow?” he asked.

“I guess so”, she replied tentatively, “If you wear these white robes and I go with you, no one will notice... but why?”

“Well if the mobile phone worked there”, Sebastian suggested as he looked at Albert, “it means we have a connection with our home in the 21st century...”

“Zat’s brilliant!” Einstein said in awe, “Vhy didn’t I sink of zat?”

“Well let’s try it”, Sebastian said eagerly.

“And if we can’t make contact we’ll just go back and get worked to death!” Jonathan continued as he gulped down more fine wine.

Eventually the delicious Egyptian feast was consumed and Lucinda took them all back to their quarters at the base of the enormous half completed pyramid.

“I’ve never had a boyfriend from the 21st century AD”, Lucinda mentioned to Jonathan as they decided to have a walk down to the banks of the River Nile.

They sat in the moon shade of some palm and olive trees. Lucinda had beautiful Middle Eastern eyes and a sensuous darkly tanned body.

“I’ve never kissed an Australian”, Lucinda whispered into Jonathan’s ear as the mirror calm Nile flowed gently by, “in fact I have never even heard of Australia...”

The Great Pyramid of Khufu

The Giza Plateau was a veritable hive of activity as thousands of slaves worked on the pyramid and locals went about their daily lives.

The students strolled along in their flowing white robes passed the huge ramp where the granite blocks that had arrived by barge along the Nile from Aswan were being schlepped ever so slowly up the pyramid Cheops.

Further over they could see the completed pyramid of Khafre, Chephren, and the smaller Menkaure, Mycerinus. Eventually they reached the entrance of Cheops and a guard nodded and gestured them in without a second glance.

Lucinda had a couple of torches which they lit and this gave them an eerie light that flickered about as they made their way along the corridors lined with polished granite.

“Try sending a text message again”, Sebastian suggested to Jonathan who took it out and pressed send. It showed No Network Coverage again.

They walked down some corridors and it was only thanks to the excellent memory of Albert that they took the correct turns and bends in the myriad of tunnels and eventually located the impressive main tomb where King Khufu would be laid to rest one day.

The same artists and various stonemasons were still working away diligently and paid scant attention to them as they strolled through the chamber and entered another tunnel.

After a while they arrived at the same location they had stopped at the previous day and Albert deciphered the hieroglyphics.

“Ya. Zis it it!” Albert announced. Cathy placed the dingo pup on the granite floor. There were no guards to worry them so Jonathan took out the mobile phone and tapped in a new message.

‘WE ARE INSIDE CHEOPS’

“Is that okay for the message?” Jonathan asked as he showed it to Sebastian who nodded in approval. Jonathan then pressed send.

“It worked!” He announced in great excitement.

“Great! This means that somehow there is network coverage right here!” Kim replied enthusiastically as he looked at Albert.

Suddenly the mobile phone sounded, ‘bip, bip... bip, bip...’ and Jonathan read the text message immediately.

‘R U SAFE ?’

“Now try and ring them!” Sebastian responded.

“Where’s Zara!” Cathy said as she searched around urgently, “I just put her down a moment ago...”

Jonathan, meanwhile, tapped in a number and pressed dial. There were some beeps and then a familiar voice.

“Is that you Jonathon?” A female voice asked incredulously at the other end.

“Yes, Mum, it’s me. We’re inside the Great Pyramid of Khufu!” Jonathan said loudly.

“I don’t believe it!” Albert said looking further down the corridor.

“What? That this mobile phone works?” Sebastian asked.

“Nine! I just saw your pup emerge out of zat vall!” Albert exclaimed as the dingo pup pranced around.

“It’s a hole again!” Kim yelled as he rushed to the place and put his hand into the solid granite stone, “hurry!” Before they could react Kim walked into the wall and vanished.

“Now I’ve seen everyzing!” Albert said nonplussed as Yvonne, Cathy, Sebastian and Jonathan followed Kim through the wall.

“Well?” said Sebastian as his head emerged from the solid stonewall, “are you coming with us?”

“Vhy not?” Albert asked as he shrugged his shoulders and looked at Arsami and Lucinda. They held hands and walked through.

On the other side of the wall they all found themselves in an identical tunnel except much more worn down. The granite wall was old and unpolished. And voices, they could here voices echoing down the corridor as the dingo pup sat at their feet gazing up at them.

“... And if you follow me here, we’ll soon reach the amazing tomb of King Khufu!” an authoritative voice announced that reverberated along the tunnel.

A group of Japanese tourists with cameras dangling around their necks walked around the bend of the corridor with a guide. They stopped in their tracks and looked at the students.

“I’m sure I’ve seen those students somewhere else”, one Japanese whispered to the other as the students and Einstein brushed by.

They walked quickly through the tomb of the King with the dingo pup prancing along happily and followed the signs in various languages that guided them to the exit.

Finally the group stepped outside into brilliant sunshine and squinted. The metropolis of Cairo was on one side with apartments and busy traffic. In the other direction they could see the Sphinx and other pyramids scattered around the Giza Plateau.

“There’s something infinitesimal about this pyramid”, Jonathan said and then slowly turned around to look at The Great Pyramid of Khufu they had just emerged from. It had a pinnacle and seemed to be complete.

“Jonathan? We can see you...” Jonathan’s mother said excitedly.

The students felt disorientated as they looked over and saw their parents waving at them. There were police cars everywhere and United Nations military were busy cordoning off the area and pushing back the assembled media. A few men approached them in suits.

“You seem okay... I’m from the Australian embassy”, a man announced with a thick Australian accent. “You’re to come with us and please don’t speak to the media...”

They were quickly ushered into a number of United Nations jeeps parked nearby and the convoy drove away at high speed escorted by police cars and motorbikes from the Cairo Police Department.

“Where are you taking us?” Sebastian asked the Australian Ambassador.

“An American hospital in central Cairo for a medical check-up”, he replied cautiously, “then to a military base where you will all board an aeroplane...”

The medical check-up revealed that no one was the worse for wear from their ordeal and the doctors paid particular attention to Albert Einstein because he was supposed to have died in 1955.

They were then flown to a secret location in Switzerland where they spent a month in a large villa. Here their story was carefully logged and scrutinised.

There was no direct proof of their tale until nine months later when Cathy gave birth to a healthy baby boy.

DNA tests from this baby matched those of DNA taken from the mummified corpse of King Khufu, which was on permanent show in a glass cabinet in the Cairo Museum for Egyptian antiquity.

Jonathan sat under the shade of a gum tree at the base of Uluru as Cathy played with the dingo pup they had adopted. Kim was seated next to them typing notes and calculations into his laptop and Yvonne wandered around impatiently looking at her watch.

“We’re back! And we had a great time!” their tour guide, Albert Harrison, said as he and a large group of students ambled down the rock. They looked over to see Sebastian asleep in the shade of Uluru.

“We climbed right to the top and no one fell off!” Albert said laughing as he ran his fingers through his long shaggy hair.

“They’re back”, Yvonne said shaking Sebastian as he slowly woke up.

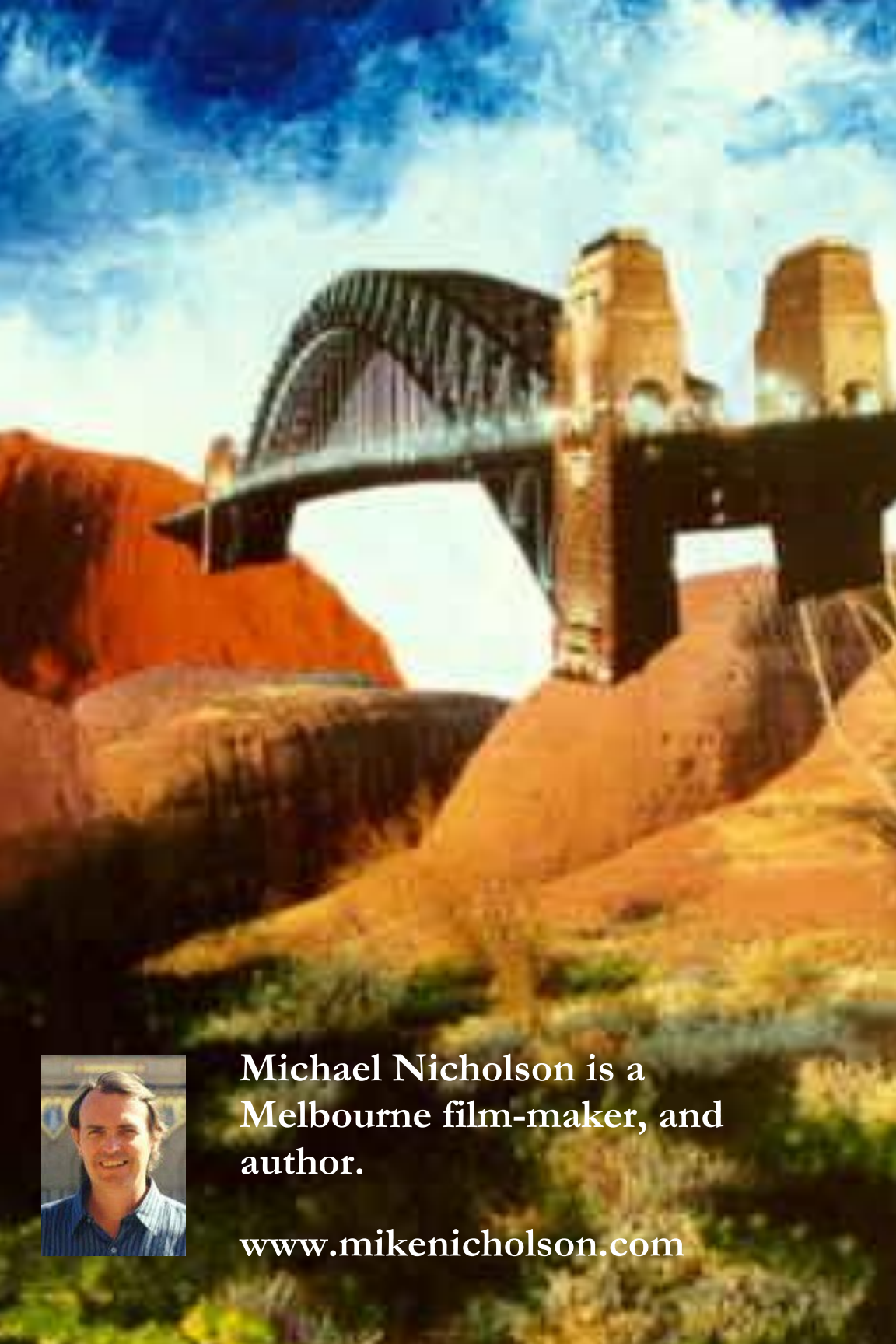
“Oh, it’s you Yvonne. I was just dozing”, Sebastian replied squinting into the late afternoon sun.

“I’m glad you didn’t climb this rock. I really enjoyed being your guide. Look, I’ve got to get back to Alice Springs...”

Yvonne said giving Sebastian a kiss on his cheek, “I hope to see you again one day.”

“Would you like a ride?” came the strangely familiar Egyptian accent of Lucinda as she stood nearby a tethered camel and a sign reading Sightseeing Tours.

The End.



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